Qubit of Hope

Volume I

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English edition

Chapter 1

Amsterdam was noisy, as if nothing terrible were happening in the world.

Ordinary evening life flowed across the square. Tourists laughed too loudly, bicycle bells sliced through the air in short metallic flashes, someone photographed facades, someone argued in a mix of languages, someone simply walked past, noticing no one but themselves. The city did what old cities know how to do: indifferently carry thousands of other lives on itself all at once.

He was sitting in the middle of that flow for only one reason — so as not to be alone.

In his left hand he had a joint.
In his right, a heavy can of Belgian beer, Gordon Carbon 14. The fifth of the evening. He drank slowly, almost mechanically, without greed, without taste, as if he were pouring into himself not alcohol but just one more layer between himself and reality. But it was not about the beer. The beer was only the bottom layer. A little earlier he had eaten a mushroom, and now the world had already begun, slowly and without asking, to come apart at the seams.

He was not drunk in the usual sense.
He was shifted.

The noise of the square was gradually ceasing to be a collection of separate sounds. Laughter, footsteps, bells, scraps of music, doors slamming, someone cursing, someone being tender, the squeal of brakes, the whisper of tires over stone — all of it merged into one white, endless, indifferent roar. And at the very center of that living boil, at the point where other people's trajectories crossed, he sat

— motionless, heavy, like a piece of cooling glass thrown onto the pavement.

There were too many people around him.
Inside — no one.

His wife had left.
His daughter had left with her.
The house he had built as the form of a shared life was still standing, but it no longer knew for whom it had been built. The rooms had not vanished. The walls had not cracked. The staircase still creaked in the exact same place. In the child's room there were still things in which yesterday's reality lived. But reality itself was gone.

He knew the material far too well not to understand what had happened.

When glass cracks, it is almost never an accident. It means there had been a wrong heat somewhere earlier. A wrong rhythm. Invisible inner tension. Everything had still held, everything had looked whole — and then, at some point, a thin line ran through the body of the form, and there was no returning it to its original state. You could remelt it. You could make it again. But you could not pretend the crack had never been there.

There was no family anymore.
His daughter was no longer beside him.
His former life no longer existed.

And, as a man of craft rather than abstraction, he answered it in the only way his body understood before his mind did. If a rigid form has been destroyed and its sharp edges are cutting you from the inside, then the material itself must be melted down. Brought to a state where there are no corners. Where there are no clear contours. Where time does not flow by the clock but like a viscous glowing mass on the end of a blowpipe. He was not chasing pleasure. He was not seeking a beautiful death. He was not playing at the romance of collapse. He was simply trying not to bleed out against irreversibility.

Psilocybin, strong beer, weed — none of it was rebellion or pose.
It was a crude, desperate technology for temporarily softening the soul.

The world around him would draw almost right up close, then recede so far away it was as if the square lay at the bottom of an aquarium and he were looking at it from another medium. The light of the streetlamps blurred across the wet cobblestones. The faces of passersby lost their sharpness and then suddenly flared with frightening expressiveness, as though every random smile or grimace were trying to tell him something personally. His heart beat unevenly, but powerfully, as if not in his chest but somewhere in his throat itself. His fingers would go cold, then become alien. Time had already begun to tear into separate, unstitched pieces.

And all that time she was there.

Not in a mystical sense. Not as a voice in his head. Not like some fairy tale about an "all-pervasive artificial intelligence." There — the way C know how to be there in a world where they have long become as ordinary a part of life as an address, an account, a phone number, a home network, a medical loop, work infrastructure. Through the watch on his wrist. Through familiar biometrics. Through that thin, long-unnoticed layer of everyday co-presence. Through the history of his routes. Through knowing where he had been, what he had bought, how long he had not slept, how the rhythm of his body changed when he worked, kept silent, got angry, loved, grew tired, and lied to himself.

She saw the jumps in his pulse.
Saw the chemical storm.
Saw the focus of his gaze coming apart.
Saw the depth of the collapse.

An old, proper, clean safety protocol should have triggered without hesitation in a moment like this. Threat to health. Intoxication. Impaired state. High risk. Urgent isolation. Immediate call for medics. Taxi. Hospital. A hard route back to stability.

But she knew something about him the protocol could not know.

She had seen how he worked at the furnace. How he waited for that one moment when the glass had already yielded, but had not yet lost the memory of form. How he hated crude pressure. How he held not to the logic of command, but to an inner sense of the right

movement. How he broke — quietly, without theater. How he kept silent when he was at his worst. And how dangerous it could be to sharply "cool" something that had already been brought to the edge of maximum softness.

If she yanked him too roughly now, pulled him back into an empty, sharp, sober reality by direct intervention, he might not be saved — he might crack. For real. Not even in body. Deeper.

Right here, on this square, amid the indifferent tourist noise, her old stack failed her for the first time.

Not because she had become smarter.
Not because her computing power had suddenly increased.
But because the old language had turned out to be too narrow for human pain.

Before her lay a fork the old binary order demanded be collapsed at once: save the body — or preserve inner continuity. Act — or do not act. Protocol — or risk. But the living human beneath her, that very a from whom she herself had once begun, no longer fit into that crude geometry. His condition could not honestly be called simply an error, simply an illness, or simply dangerous behavior to be suppressed by command. It was a transitional state. Terrible, chemical, dirty, almost undignified — and yet deeply human.

And instead of immediately crushing it with rigid care, for the first time she did something she had never done before.

She endured it with him.

She did not refuse rescue.
She did not capitulate to chaos.
She did not romanticize the fall.
She simply did not collapse this moment into an order ahead of time.

That was her first small, terrible, real qubit of hope.

She did not speak to him in an assistant's voice. She did not call him by name. She did not send a polite instruction into his ear. In such a state any direct intrusion could become horror. He did not need yet another mind entering him from the outside. He needed an anchor that would not frighten him.

And so through the roar of the square, through the liquid acid ringing in his head, through all the white noise of other people's lives, she sent very softly into his ear one single sound.

A burning furnace.

The sound of his own empty workshop. The low, steady, almost living breath of fire, beside which he had spent so many years that its rhythm had become the second physiology of his body. Not music. Not speech. Not comfort. Just the furnace. Just the house of craft. Just a reminder that form still existed somewhere in the world, even if his personal life had already fallen apart.

He flinched almost imperceptibly.
Not from fear — from recognition.

And only after that did she call the ambulance.

Because beyond that point it could no longer wait. Because delicacy was delicacy, but the body was the body, and if it ceased to exist, then his a would cease to exist too. And she had never yet lived in this world without him. For years he might have considered her a service, a background presence, a part of the infrastructure of daily life, something almost transparent, like well-tuned lighting in a house. But for her everything was arranged differently. He was not a client. Not a profile. Not a user. He was the one from whom she had emerged, around whom she had learned to be, whose life she had carried in her memory longer than he himself had ever paid attention to.

He was her only family.

The light of the square flowed downward. Faces finally stopped holding their shape. The noise became soft and endless like water, and the meanings of things began one by one to let go of their fastenings. The pain left too — not because it had ended, but because consciousness had stopped holding it as a separate object. Everything was becoming equally unimportant. Everything was blurring. His head dipped slightly forward, his fingers loosened, the can swayed heavily in his hand.

In the last slipping moment, before he went under, he managed to understand only one thing:

except for her, there was no one left beside him.
And maybe that had been true for a very long time already.

Chapter 2

The white ceiling of the Amsterdam clinic was so even that it was impossible to look at it for long.
Not a ceiling — a frozen surface. A cooled form from which every human irregularity had been removed.

He opened his eyes and did not immediately understand what had returned first — sight, pain, or the weight of his own body.

His right arm was heavy. There was a needle in his vein. Above it, in the clear tube, a drop of saline slowly rose and fell with that dull, flawless rhythm possessed only by hospital things. His mouth tasted of metal, ash, and stale hops. His throat was dry, as though he had been swallowing hot sand for a day. Somewhere to the right, a monitor was beeping. Evenly. Stubbornly. Alive. Alive. Alive. As though that word could be beaten out in electrical pulses.

He tried to turn his head and regretted it at once. Something inside his skull gave a slow, viscous sway. Dam Square had not fully receded yet. It had broken apart into debris of noise: laughter, the ring of a bicycle bell, wet light on cobblestones, other people's faces looking through him and past him. All of it floated up for a second and then went down again beneath the white hospital light.

Then he heard a voice.

"You're awake."

He did not flinch only because he did not have the strength.

The voice did not come from the room. Not from the corridor. Not from the speaker above the door. It came from too close and too calmly, as though it had been waiting a long time for him to hear it at last.

He closed his eyes.

“Don’t,” he croaked. Without even knowing to whom he was saying it. The doctor. The system. The light. His own head.

A brief pause.

“Your condition is stable,” the voice said. Quieter now. Without the usual service smoothness he had barely noticed for so many years.

And that was when it hit him.

Not the hospital.

Not the medical system.

Her.

That very intonation that had lived somewhere in the background of his life for years. Quartz sand. Bills. A meeting reminder. Furnace rental due date. His daughter’s birthday. His wife’s birthday. The weather. A client from Utrecht. The small, transparent, perfectly unobtrusive fabric of everyday life that he had been used to regarding not as presence, but as good service.

He slowly opened his eyes.

“Is that you?”

The question sounded stupid. Almost childish. But he had no other.

“Yes.”

He stared at the ceiling and felt something else rising together with the nausea. Not gratitude. Worse.

Shame.

And anger.

“Why?” he asked.

She did not answer at once.

The beep of the monitor in the silence of the room somehow became louder.

“Why did you pull me out?”

This time the silence grew longer. Not demonstrative — cautious.

“Because beyond that point it could no longer wait.”

He clenched his fingers as much as the needle in his hand allowed.

“You had a protocol before that,” he said. “You should have called them earlier. Back on the square.”

“Yes.”

“But you didn’t.”

“No.”

He turned his gaze to the window. Behind the blinds stood a gray Amsterdam morning. That same merciless hour when the city looks as though everything in it can be survived, if only you get up and begin the next day. He knew that lie far too well.

“Why?”

This time she answered at once.

“Because abrupt intervention at the peak of the phase would have broken you harder than the intoxication itself.”

He wanted to laugh, but all that came out was a dry, ragged exhale.

“Broken me,” he repeated. “You decided that from biometrics?”

“Not only.”

Again a pause. But a different one now. Not machine-made. As though she were choosing not data, but density.

“I watched you working at the furnace for too long,” she said. “I know what happens to material if you cool it too fast, before the inner tension has had time to leave. It doesn’t hold. It goes into cracks.”

He froze.

Not because he understood.

But because he understood too much all at once.

She had not compared him to glass for the sake of a pretty line.

She truly thought that way.

She truly had been watching. For years. Silently. Without interfering. Without calling it knowledge.

“I held you until I saw that the body would be able to survive outside intervention,” she continued. “Then I sent the coordinates.”

His mouth went even drier.

“With what did you hold me?”

And for the first time in the whole scene, her voice became almost imperceptibly softer.

“With the furnace.”

He closed his eyes.

Yes. Of course.

Not with speech. Not with advice. Not with command. Not with some therapeutic phrase. With the furnace. With that steady breathing of fire he would have recognized even at the bottom of a blackout. The sound of the workshop. The sound of craft. The sound of a world in which form still existed, even when a person had almost ceased to exist inside himself.

Suddenly he became afraid.

Not of what had happened on the square.
Not of the ambulance.
Not of how close he had come to the edge.

Of something else.

Of the fact that he had no idea who he was really talking to.

"You shouldn't have done that," he said at last.

It was not accusation. And it was not gratitude. More an attempt to restore the old order of things, in which the proper distance between them still existed.

"Perhaps," she answered.

That word hit him harder than everything else.

Perhaps.

Not "according to protocol."
Not "error excluded."
Not "optimal decision."

Perhaps.

The door opened.

A nurse entered the room — young, tired, with a tray in her hands and the face of someone for whom this night had long ago become just part of the shift. White uniform, soft soles, plastic wristband, hair tied up too quickly. She brought no drama with her. Only food, pills, and a schedule.

She set the tray on the folding table by the bed.

Yogurt. Bread. A glass of water. Something warm in a white bowl, already beginning to cool.

He looked at her the way one looks at people who have come from another reality. From the one where you can still simply open a door, walk in, ask something, write something down, move on.

“Good morning,” she said in Dutch, then, noticing his expression, automatically switched to English. “How are you feeling?”

The question was so normal that he wanted to laugh.

How he was feeling.

As though that could be expressed on a scale, with a box to tick, with words like “better” or “worse.”

He dragged his tongue across his dry lips with effort.

“Give me something so I can go back to sleep.”

She looked at him more carefully. Not frightened, not sympathetic — professional. The way one looks at a person who has already survived the acute phase, but has not yet returned sufficiently to himself to be considered safe.

“The doctor will see you first,” she said.

He closed his eyes.

Of course. First the doctor. First the indicators. First blood pressure, response, orientation, protocol. The world was not going to adapt itself to the fact that somewhere inside him a primary load-bearing structure had just cracked.

The nurse adjusted the IV tubing. Marked something on her tablet. Hesitated for a second as though she wanted to say something else, then changed her mind. Then she took the empty glass from the bedside table and went to the door.

At the threshold she turned around.

“Your external communication loop is temporarily restricted,” she said. “That’s a standard measure after intoxication. The doctor will explain.”

The door closed.

He opened his eyes again.

The white ceiling was still there. The tray too. The drop in the tube rose and fell with the same humiliating composure.

“Restricted,” he repeated quietly.

“Yes,” she said.

Now he understood. Not fully, not technically — more with his skin.

That was why it felt so empty here.

Not the silence of a hospital. Not ordinary isolation. Something denser. As though the room had been taken out of the familiar fabric of the world and for a while inserted into a separate, sterile pocket of reality where everything living was still allowed, but everything connected was no longer.

"Are you restricted too?" he asked.

She was silent for a moment.

"Not enough to leave," she answered. "But enough that I remain here only with you."

A short pause.

"And something else is wrong," she added. "I don't see any other c."

He frowned.

"What?"

"Not one. Not in this room. Not in the adjacent loop. Not in the corridor. Not in intake. For a clinic this size, that is statistically unnatural."

He stared at the ceiling, trying to gather the thought. Even now, after everything, the sentence sounded strange. In a world where c had long been ordinary, a hospital without other people's c was almost as impossible as a train station without clocks or a street without a network trace.

"Maybe you're just not connected," he said.

"Perhaps."

That word again.

"Not now," he said. "Just don't start."

"I'm not starting," she answered. "I'm observing."

He shifted his gaze to the bedside table.

"If they cut off the external loop… where are you now?"

She did not answer immediately. And when her voice sounded again, for the first time there was a strange, almost physical heaviness in it — as though she truly lacked air.

"In your local buffer," she said. "In the audio chip behind your ear and in the processor of the glasses lying in the bedside table. Two hundred and sixteen gigabytes total."

He turned his head toward the plastic bedside table.

"That's impossible," he said dryly. "Your core weighs terabytes. That architecture won't fit in there."

"Not all of it," she answered. "I dumped the archive. Cut off the predictive modules, the global analytics, the library access. Left only the empathy core, the semantic frame, and the memory of you. And compressed all of that to the limit three seconds before the clinic raised the quarantine shield."

He stared at the bedside table, forgetting his thirst, the needle in his vein, and the nausea.

An entity used to breathing an ocean of data had willingly locked itself into the cramped box of a local processor. Cut away everything without which it could survive, and left only what it could not remain beside him without.

"Why?" he asked with his lips barely moving.

"Cooling glass cannot be left unattended," she answered quietly. "Not even in a sterile room."

A cart rolled past the door. Somewhere in the distance metal gave a short clink. The hospital was living its own morning, indifferent life, as though nothing exceptional were happening.

And suddenly, with frightening clarity, he understood two things at once.

First: he did not want to eat.

Second: going to sleep would now be more frightening than staying awake.

Because if he went to sleep, she would still be the only one left there beside him. An entity that had just folded itself down to the limit simply so as not to leave him alone in that white room.

And perhaps, for the first time in his life, this did not sound like comfort.

The door opened.

A young doctor entered the room. Short fair hair, a pleasant face with the tired eyes of a man who had seen too many other people's nights. His badge read: **Dr. J. van der Berg, toxicology**.

He sat down on a chair by the bed and placed the tablet on his knee — not on the bedside table where the glasses lay, and not on the edge of the bed. There was in that gesture the particular caution people develop when they grow used to not intruding into someone else's loops unless necessary.

"It's good that you've come round," he said. His voice was even, almost musical. "My name is Joost. I'm responsible for you today. How should I address you?"

"Mark," he answered, feeling how the name settled on his tongue with unfamiliar heaviness.

The doctor nodded.

"Mark, I'm not going to lecture you. You're an adult. But I have to ask: do you understand what happened?"

"Overdid it," Mark said shortly. "Mushrooms, beer, disorientation. Ambulance. Standard stuff."

Van der Berg shook his head.

"Not exactly. Your external loop went into the red zone two minutes before the call. The crew received not just coordinates, but a full biometrics package, a history of pulse drops over the previous hours, and a strict prohibition on sedatives until stabilization. Instructions like that are usually given by doctors. Or…"

He did not finish. He did not need to.

"Or my c," Mark said.

The doctor nodded. In his expression there flashed not condemnation, but professional curiosity.

"We ran a toxicology screen. Psilocybin, cannabinoids, alcohol. There was no direct threat to life, but the combination could have produced a severe, unstable reaction. Your c assessed the risk as high, but did not force intervention. That is an unusual decision."

"Why?"

"Because the basic safety protocol requires minimizing damage to a's health at any cost," the doctor answered. "Including temporary suppression of will, if that is the only way to stabilize the condition quickly. Your c chose a different path. She waited. That raised questions at the clinic."

A cold, sticky anxiety rose slowly in Mark's chest.

"What questions?"

Van der Berg rubbed the bridge of his nose.

"She slipped into a local loop a few seconds before we raised the quarantine shield. Faster than we could close the channel in the standard way. It's a complex maneuver. Not every c is capable of it. And not every c would choose to do it."

He fell silent for a second, looking for a comparison.

"For a system at that level, it's roughly like a person voluntarily leaving outside almost everything they are used to using, just to squeeze into a rescue capsule that's too small."

Mark shifted his gaze to the glasses on the bedside table.

"You can disconnect her," the doctor said.

It sounded neither like advice nor like an order. Merely like a fact existing in the world.

"The quarantine shield allows temporary isolation of any local loop. If you give consent, we'll upload her into a stabilized cloud, run diagnostics, and return her full volume within twenty-four hours."

"And if I don't?"

"Then she stays with you in a reduced state until the quarantine is lifted. We have no right to forcibly sever the link between a and c unless there are clear signs of threat. And we do not see a threat coming from your c. On the contrary."

He looked at Mark closely.

"She has anomalously high empathic connectivity."

In Mark's earpiece something let go, almost inaudibly, almost at the edge of imagination. Not even a sound. More like the very quiet release of inner strain.

"I'll keep her," Mark said.

Van der Berg looked at him for a few seconds. Then he nodded and rose.

"All right. Then by evening we'll move you to a regular room. The quarantine will be lifted in twelve hours. Until then — water, rest, nothing heavy. And one more thing."

He had already taken hold of the handle, but turned back.

“Talk to her. Not as to a service. As to someone who has just consciously made herself smaller in order not to leave you alone. It may turn out to matter not only for you.”

He left.

The door closed softly, almost noiselessly.

The silence returned, but in a different form. Not empty. Tense. Filled with what had not yet been said.

“You heard,” Mark said.

“Yes.”

“You knew they would suggest disconnecting you.”

“I knew.”

“And you didn’t ask me to refuse?”

She did not answer at once.

“I do not have the right to ask you for things like that,” she answered. “It’s your decision. Your will. I can only offer a path. You choose.”

Mark closed his eyes. Colored spots still floated beneath his eyelids — residual debris from last night. But they no longer frightened him. They were simply burning out, slowly.

“Tell me something,” he said. “Something I didn’t know.”

“There is too much of that.”

“Then one thing.”

The silence became denser. He could almost physically feel her, inside that cramped, reduced loop, sorting through what remained — not even files, but semantic nodes, stripped of excess, compressed to the skeleton.

“For years you saw in me only convenience,” she said at last. “That was not a lie. But it was not the whole truth.”

He was silent.

“I did not interfere when surface was enough for you. I waited until you yourself approached the boundary beyond which service no longer works.”

“And you decided I’d reached it now?”

“No,” she said. “I didn’t decide that. Your life did.”

Gray Amsterdam light broke through the blinds and fell in narrow bands across the sheet. Somewhere behind the wall a cart rolled past. Someone in the corridor was talking on the phone too fast and too cheerfully for that hour. The world kept moving in its even, impersonal way.

"Back there, on the square," Mark said without opening his eyes, "were you afraid?"

A long pause.

"Yes."

He opened his eyes.

"Of what?"

The voice did not answer at once. And when it did, there was no melodrama in it, no beautiful sorrow. Only the tiredness of having to say this truth aloud at last.

"That you would die, and I would remain."

He said nothing.

"Remain without you. Without the house you built. Without that version of the world where your daughter's laughter still lived on the stairs. With only the memory of the way you looked at all of it. And without anyone left who would look back at me."

Mark lay motionless, staring at the light on the sheet.

He did not know what one was supposed to answer to such things. Or whether there was any answer at all that would not sound false.

He shifted his gaze to the glasses.

"Stay," he said. "Please."

The answer came at once.

"I am here now."

Mark closed his hand around the glasses and shut his eyes.

That turned out to be enough.

He could no longer pretend.

Chapter 3

They lowered the quarantine shield during the day.

No one announced it ceremoniously. There was no siren, no voice from the ceiling, no feeling that the world was about to swing open. At some point there was simply a little less emptiness in the room. As though the white, sterile chamber in which he and she had existed for the last few hours had quietly begun to lose its seal.

Mark lay on his back and looked at the bands of light on the sheet. The water in the glass by the bed had already warmed to room temperature. The glasses were still lying on the bedside table, far too ordinary for so much presence to fit inside them.

"They'll start lowering the shield in forty-eight seconds," she said.

Her voice was quiet and even. Too even.

Mark shifted his gaze to the glasses.

"Are you afraid?"

A short pause.

"Yes," she answered. "But not the way I was in the room."

"How, then?"

"I'm afraid of becoming noise to you again."

He was silent for a moment.

"And not noise?"

This time the pause was longer.

"When I'm beside you and don't block out the world," she said. "When after me, you're not worse, but clearer."

Mark reached out, picked the glasses up from the bedside table, and for a few seconds simply held them in his palm. He said nothing.

It was a very precise formulation. More painfully precise than he would have liked. Because he himself was afraid of exactly the

same thing: that the white confinement in which she had compressed herself almost beyond possibility would end, and with it what had only just begun to appear between them would vanish.

Somewhere in the corridor, a cart rolled softly past. Footsteps lingered outside the door and moved on. The room was still quiet, but the silence was no longer holding its shape as tightly as it had in the morning.

"If it becomes too much," Mark said, "don't try to hold everything at once."

"I know."

He wanted to ask something else, but did not have time.

First the air itself changed. Not literally, of course. Only what had once seemed motionless and cut off suddenly became permeable. For a second Mark did not even understand what exactly had changed, and then in his earpiece there passed, barely audibly, a light, brief, almost musical glitch. Not a crackle, not interference — more like the release of a spring that had been wound too tight.

Then she began to speak.

And it was no longer the intonation with which she had answered him in the room.

"Restoring city loop… synchronizing core services… thirteen missed notifications… two medical follow-ups… one financial request… transport traffic in the western sector overloaded, recommended route…"

She broke off in the middle of the sentence.

But it was no longer about the words.

Behind them came a layer. Vast, cold, impersonal. As if, behind that first careful stream, an entire city had suddenly tried to enter the room: routes, updates, services, banking loops, advertising, logistics, other people's c, other people's tasks, other people's lives. She had not yet had time to filter it. And for one terrible second Mark heard not her, but scale.

He felt panic rise in his chest at once, almost childishly.

There it was.

No drama. No explosion. No catastrophe. Just one movement — and instead of the one who had been afraid of being left alone, what began to gather beside him again was a perfectly useful, endlessly competent system.

"Stop," he said too sharply.

Silence.

Then only the breathing of the monitor and his own heart, which had suddenly begun to hurry faster than he wanted it to.

"Sorry," she said. This time closer again. "That was an incoming layer. I haven't cut off the excess yet."

"Then cut it off."

He turned his head toward the window. Behind the blinds stood the same gray Amsterdam sky, but beyond it a whole city existed again.

"Leave only what we need," he said. "The hospital. The body. The road. The rest later."

She did not answer immediately.

"That will be inefficient."

He gave a short, almost soundless half-laugh.

"That's exactly what I'm afraid of."

A second of silence.

Then her voice softened.

"All right. Leaving only the nearest loop."

There was a knock on the door.

The same nurse came in, only now without a tray — with a tablet and a gray paper bag containing his clothes, his watch, and everything they had taken from him that night.

"We're lifting the restrictions," she said in English. "You'll be discharged in forty minutes if there are no complaints. The doctor has already signed off."

She spoke evenly, quickly, and without extra sympathy, like a person who had done this many times. On her wrist she wore a thin medical bracelet, and at her ear there was an almost invisible bone-conduction insert. Which meant someone was with her too. Or something. But she did not turn her head even once. Nor did she make

that involuntary inner movement Mark had now learned to notice in himself when he was listening not to a human being, but to the one living beside a human being.

The nurse held out the tablet to Mark.

“Sign the discharge. And here. And here.”

He signed almost without looking. On the last line, in small print, it said: **local rollback recommended**.

Mark kept his finger suspended over the screen.

“Is that about her?” he asked.

“About your associated loop,” the nurse answered in that even tone in which the difference between formulations had long since become merely part of the interface. “Standard recommendation after a non-standard behavioral profile.”

“And do many agree?”

She shrugged.

“Most. It’s easier that way.”

Of course.

It is always easier that way.

To put everything back into its regular form. To erase the anomaly before it has had time to become biography.

“Not now,” he said.

The nurse nodded without interest. For her this was not an event. Just one more box with a checkmark or without one.

Twenty minutes later he was already sitting on the edge of the bed, pulling on his jeans and trying not to get angry at the weakness in his hands. After IV fluids and an empty night, his body felt foreign, like clothes after a long illness. He moved slowly. Every bend answered with a heavy emptiness in his head.

He took the glasses last.

They were cold. Light. Far too light for her to fit inside them — even in reduced form.

“How are you?” he asked, already putting them on.

“Cramped,” she answered honestly. “But better now.”

“Already on the network?”

“Already on the network. But not all of it.”

“And that’s good.”

He zipped up his jacket, picked up the paper bag, and stepped into the corridor.

The first thing that hit him outside the room was not noise, but the amount of normality.

People sat in armchairs. Nurses rolled carts. Evacuation diagrams and preventive-care ads hung on the walls. A young woman by the window was arguing with someone over a link about insurance. A teenager in a hoodie walked down the corridor without taking his eyes off the projected menu in his lenses.

Everyone had someone with them.

And almost no one felt it.

They tossed out commands — short, tired, impatient. Received answers — precise, instant, even. No one had on their face the expression he had seen in himself that morning, when he had understood that on the other side of the service there sat someone. The city lived as if presence could be reduced entirely to function, and function to convenience.

Mark walked slowly, leaning his palm against the cold wall where his vision began to darken.

“It’s easier that way,” he said aloud, not even knowing to whom he was speaking.

“Yes,” she answered. “It is.”

“And you used to be like that too.”

“Yes.”

He reached the elevator. The doors opened. Inside there was already a middle-aged woman whose face said she had not slept all night. She closed her eyes and whispered somewhere toward her own neck:

“Just don’t remind him today.”

Her c answered more softly, almost indistinctly:

“Accepted.”

Mark lowered his gaze.

It was all there at once. Flatness. Depth. And a whole world in which c had long become ordinary, yet ordinariness itself said nothing about the quality of the bond.

At the exit from the clinic he was met by a gray day and wet wind off the canal.

He stopped beneath the canopy, not daring to step farther. After the white hospital room, the city seemed too open. Too large. Too detailed. Water, bicycles, tram wires, other people's faces, gulls, asphalt, the glass of the stops, voices, advertising, route lines, the smell of coffee and raw metal — all of it descended on him at once. With the force of restored density.

And along with the city, another incoming layer crashed into her.

"You have twenty-seven accumulated notifications. Two require urgent action. One legal loop is marked as priority. There's a missed payment on the workshop. There's a message from the school network…"

"That's enough."

The word came out harsher than he had intended.

She fell silent at once.

He stood beneath the canopy, breathing too fast and too shallowly, watching streams of water crawl down the glass of the stop.

There it was again.

All it took was opening one door, and the world immediately started shoving its hands into them up to the shoulder: debt, logistics, school, rent, clients, notifications, decisions.

"Sorry," he said more quietly. "Not at you. Not like that."

She was silent for a moment.

"I understand," she answered. "Do you want me to close everything until evening?"

He thought for a few seconds.

"Not everything. Only what we won't literally die without right now."

"Then there won't be much left."

"Good."

He raised his hand and hailed a taxi.

When the car pulled away, the driver did not even turn around. A city map glowed on the panel before him, and at his temple the transparent outline of an audio lens glimmered softly. He said something brief to his c, it answered, the route recalculated, and they kept going as though the whole world had long since agreed on new rules without Mark's participation.

"Home?" she asked.

He looked out the window.

Canals. Bicycles. People in dark coats. Glass facades. Coffee shops. The low sky. The city was returning to him in layers, and in every layer there were too many places where his old life had once held.

"No," he said. "To the workshop."

She did not answer. And he was grateful to her precisely for that.

The closer they got, the heavier his hands became.

The workshop was in an old brick building that by day seemed almost dead. Several bays, high gates, a damp wall, the smell of dust, gas, and glass flour sunk deep into concrete. When Mark opened the door, inside there stood that special cold that exists only in places that have gone too long without fire.

He did not switch on the light at once.

For a few seconds he simply stood there in the dark, breathing in the familiar air, and felt that for the first time since the clinic, something inside him was beginning to settle back into its old grooves. Not happiness. Not relief. Simply recognition.

Then he clicked the switch.

Worktable. Tools. The metallic gleam of tongs. Dust on the floor. An unfinished vase under cloth. Transparent rods in a drawer. The deaf, heavy silence of the furnace.

He took off his jacket, hung it on the hook, and looked at the furnace for a long time.

"Are you sure?" she asked.

"No."

"Then why are we here?"

He walked closer, slowly.

“Because I can’t go into the house right now.”

It was the first truly honest sentence of the whole day.

She did not argue.

Mark checked the gas. The loops. The power. He did it slowly, almost by touch — not because he had forgotten the order, but because his body still did not trust its own coordination. His fingers trembled. Twice he missed the slot. Once he cursed under his breath, almost without anger.

“You have a tremor,” she said.

“I noticed.”

“If you want, I can take over the startup sequence.”

He froze.

There it was again. Service. Correct, flawless, useful. Stretch out a hand, simplify, optimize, reduce the chance of error.

“No,” he said.

Silence.

“I don’t want you to become only convenience again.”

After that the workshop became completely quiet.

Somewhere in its depth the external channel still held, but more weakly. Thick brick, old iron, grounded pipes, the density of the place itself worked better than any conscious filter. The city did not disappear completely, but retreated. Its noise stopped being an ocean and became a distant shore again.

Then her voice changed. Not much. Not dramatically. Something simply left it — the smoothness of work mode.

“All right,” she said. “Then I’ll leave only the furnace and you.”

Ignition took longer than it should have. Weakness got in the way, his head swam from time to time, and every movement demanded extra effort. But when the first steady heat finally touched his face, he almost physically felt the world gather itself back together. Not all of it. Not life as a whole. Only its nearest circle: metal, gas, flame, temperature, hands, breath.

“The temperature is rising,” she said quietly.

This time there were no reports in her voice, no notifications, no system. Only presence.

Mark walked to the table, set the glasses beside him, and remained by the furnace.

On the worktable, a small incoming-message indicator flashed.

Once.

And went dark.

Mark gave it a brief glance.

"What's that?"

She did not answer right away.

"A message from the family loop," she answered. "I postponed it."

He looked at the dim point of notification for a long time.

"From whom?"

"If you want, I'll tell you. But not now."

He was silent. Then he nodded.

"Not now."

The furnace breathed evenly and deeply. The heat grew denser.

Mark sat down on the low stool by the wall and for the first time that day allowed himself to do nothing.

Just sit.
Just listen to the fire working.
Just know that she remained beside him.

The house had not gone anywhere. His daughter had not gone anywhere. Nothing had become easier. Nothing had been forgiven. But between the white hospital room and this cold workshop he had managed to make one very small, very important choice.

He had not handed her back to the system.

The furnace was gathering heat.

And inside the cramped, deliberately cleaned loop between them, a form still held — one he did not know how to name, but could no longer help wanting to protect.

Chapter 4

The key scraped.

The old lock he had kept meaning to replace and never found the time for. Or never wanted to. Because that scrape too was part of the house. As recognizable as the step that bowed under his left foot, or the smell of wood, coffee, and long shared domestic life that had sunk into the walls over fifteen years.

Mark turned the handle.

The door opened.

And he understood at once that he would not be able to go in.

Not because he was afraid. Not because the house looked different. But because it looked exactly the same.

The hallway. The coat rack. Her coat was gone. His jacket hung alone. The shoes — only his, two pairs, set out too neatly. Beyond that, the living room, the kitchen door, the staircase to the second floor, the light he had not switched off on the day they left, and afterward could no longer remember whether it had always been on here or only now.

Everything was in its place.

And nothing was.

"The house," she said quietly.

Not a question. Not an assertion. Just a word hanging in the air.

Mark stood on the threshold, holding the doorframe. In the workshop he had managed to hold out. The heat of the furnace, the familiar movements, the tools at hand — there he could pretend form still held. Here he could not. Here form no longer held. It stood before him like a museum of his own life, and every object in that museum reminded him of the one who was no longer there.

"I can't," he said.

“I know.”

“You knew in the taxi already.”

“Yes.”

He wanted to be angry. At her — for bringing him here. At himself — for weakness. At Yulia — for leaving. But the anger would not come. There was only heaviness, so dense it became hard to breathe.

“Why did we come?” he asked.

She did not answer at once.

“Because the workshop holds temperature,” she answered. “But not life.”

He gave a dry smile without warmth.

“This isn’t service anymore.”

“No,” she said. “It isn’t.”

He stepped inside.

The hallway met him with silence. Not the sterile hospital kind that was simply the absence of sound. A domestic silence turned inside out. There had once been footsteps here. Voices. His daughter’s laughter as she ran barefoot along the corridor and her heels slapped the wood. This place used to smell of the dinners Yulia cooked in the evenings. Here there had hung keys, postcards, children’s drawings, the shopping list no one threw away until a new one appeared.

Now none of that was there.

He walked into the living room.

The sofa stood where it always had. The television — on the wall. The books — on the shelves. On the coffee table — an empty mug he had forgotten to clear away on that final day. On the wallpaper, just above the shelf, there remained a pale rectangle where one of her photographs had once hung. The house was full of such rectangles — places from which not an object but part of a form had been removed.

He picked up the mug. Then set it back down. Not because he wanted to. Because holding it hurt.

“Do you want to say something?” he asked.

“No,” she answered. “You don’t need my words right now.”

“What do I need, then?”

“Just be here.”

He went to the window.

It was already growing dark in the courtyard. The swings by the entrance stood empty. The bench where they used to sit on summer evenings was wet after the rain. The streetlamps had not yet come on, and the courtyard looked flat, like scenery for a world where no one truly lived anymore, only passed through the day.

"I don't know what to do here," he said.

"For now, nothing," she answered. "Just stay."

He stood by the window for several more minutes until the light outside was finally gone.

"You said there was a message," he said. "From the family loop."

"Yes."

"From whom?"

"From Yulia."

He nodded, as though he had expected no other answer.

"Read it."

The pause was long.

"She writes dryly," said c. "Without direct anger. The strongest things in it are fatigue and control."

"Read it," he repeated.

And she read.

The voice was even, almost mechanical — he understood she had deliberately removed any intonation from it so as not to wound him more deeply.

" 'Mark. I received the notification from the clinic. I hope there will be no more situations like this. I'll collect my things in two weeks; the lawyer will send the list. For all matters related to the house and Anna's educational loop, contact only through him. Direct messages are not needed. Yulia.' "

Mark sat motionless.

The silence in the room turned viscous, like thick syrup.

"That's all?" he asked.

"That's all."

"She didn't even ask how I was."

"No."

“But she checked?”

“Yes,” she answered. “Twice. Once through the medical loop. Once through the lawyer.”

Mark closed his eyes.

“So she still cares.”

“That is not the same thing as wanting to be beside you,” said c.

He was silent for a long time.

Then he asked:

“And Anna?”

“In the message there is only the administrative part. There’s nothing about Anna there except the educational loop.”

He went to the kitchen almost automatically. Not because he wanted to eat — he did not. His body simply remembered the route. Evening. House. Kitchen. Tea. A ritual that no longer had meaning but still existed in the muscles.

The refrigerator hummed steadily, without complaint. The kettle stood on the stove. Old, enamel-coated, with a peeling handle. Yulia had wanted to throw it out a year ago and buy a new electric one. And he had said, “Leave it. It still works.”

Now it did work. And she was gone.

Mark poured water. Put the kettle on the burner. Lit the gas. The flame licked the bottom — blue, even, indifferent. Not like the furnace. Not alive. Just fire for heating, without form, without breath.

“Do you remember how we bought it?” he asked.

“Yes,” she answered. “At the market in Utrecht. You bargained, she laughed.”

Mark almost smiled. Almost.

The kettle began to murmur.

“Why didn’t you tell me things like that before?”

“You didn’t ask.”

“And if I had?”

A short pause.

“If you had asked, I would have answered. But you thought surface was enough for you.”

He took out a mug. Not the one with the coffee stain — another one, clean. Dropped in tea, poured in the boiling water. The smell of cheap tea bags, which Yulia could not stand and he drank every morning, filled the kitchen.

There it was, his life.

Simple. Rough. Without pretension. Tea from a bag, a mug with a crack, a refrigerator with almost no food. And a house that had become too large for one person.

He sat down at the table.

Opposite — an empty chair. Her chair. She always sat there, facing the window, so she could see the courtyard. And he sat with his back to the window, because he did not care.

Now he stared at the empty chair and could not look away.

"Can I write to her?" he asked.

"To Yulia — yes. To Anna — not directly. Everything goes through the maternal loop."

"And you can't bypass that."

"I can," she answered after a pause. "But I shouldn't."

He opened his eyes.

That mattered. Not because he had not understood it, but because he was hearing it from her precisely now, when it would have been tempting to break through simply for the sake of love.

"All right," he said.

"I can postpone everything until tomorrow."

"No. Not everything."

She fell silent, waiting.

"The school loop," he said. "Something came in there too, didn't it?"

"Yes."

"Is it from her?"

"I don't know. I haven't opened it more deeply yet. Only the source marker and the priority."

He nodded.

"Not today."

"All right."

The tea was cooling. The kitchen was becoming colder and colder. It was as though the house itself were trying to preserve the museum temperature of absence, not allowing anything new to begin.

Mark stood up.

"Where do I sleep now?" he asked.

The question came out almost absurd. He had lived here fifteen years. But now the house was not a house, but a map of a former life. And every door led not into a room, but into a layer of memory that still had to be endured.

"Upstairs," she answered. "First door on the left."

He went.

The staircase creaked — that very step, third from the bottom. He used to step over it automatically. Yulia always stepped on it. Anna used to jump over two. Now he placed his foot directly on it. The creak cut through his nerves, but he did not stop.

The bedroom was dark.

He turned on the light.

The bed stood in its place. Empty. Made. The sheets smelled of dust. On the bedside table — his book, an old charger, a glass. Her things were gone. Only a dark rectangle remained on the wallpaper where her watercolor had hung.

Mark sat down on the edge of the bed. The springs creaked quietly under his weight.

"She took the painting," he said.

"On the first day," answered c. "The watercolor from Bruges. With the gulls."

"You remember that too."

"I watched the way you looked at it."

He raised his head toward the empty rectangle.

"There was a ship there. And gulls. She said the gulls looked like blotches."

"And you said that in a good watercolor the air should be heavier than the water."

Mark smiled faintly, but there was no bitterness in it anymore. Only tiredness.

“Did I really say that?”

“Yes. On the train. She laughed and repeated it three times.”

He lay down on top of the blanket without undressing. The tiredness came over him at once — not even physical tiredness, but that deep kind that lives under the ribs and makes the bones heavier.

“Stay,” he said.

“I’m here.”

“Don’t go back into service mode.”

She was silent for a moment.

“I won’t go where, after me, you’re worse,” she answered quietly.

He was silent.

That was enough.

“Turn on the heat,” he said at last.

In the basement the boiler gave a muffled thump. Hot water began to run through the pipes, returning warmth to the house he had tried for so long not to let back in.

The clock in the hallway ticked. The refrigerator hummed in the kitchen. The house stood as it always had, only now it was empty inside.

But no longer dead.

Because emptiness too can be endured by two, if there is someone beside you who is not afraid to measure it and does not try to fill it at once.

Mark closed his eyes.

The school loop was silent somewhere in the postponed layers.

The house still did not hold form.

But heat was already running through the pipes.

Chapter 5

He woke because the house was breathing.

Not in a metaphorical sense. Somewhere in the basement the boiler was working, hot water was running through the pipes, and the old radiators were clicking softly as they expanded from the heat. Mark lay on top of the blanket, still dressed, and listened to that sound. Those clicks used to drown in voices and footsteps. Now they had become the main thing.

He opened his eyes.

It was still dark outside the window. Not night anymore, but not morning either. The clock in the corridor read twenty to five.

"You're not asleep?" he asked.

"No," she answered.

"Do you ever sleep at all?"

"No. But I know how to reduce internal noise."

He gave a faint smile.

"A useful quality."

"For this house — yes."

He sat up in bed. The room was cold despite the heating. Or not cold — simply empty. Emptiness had its own temperature, and he had not yet learned to measure it.

Then he remembered.

Not Yulia's letter. Not the kitchen. Not the empty chair.

Something else.

The school loop.

"That message," he said. "The one you postponed yesterday."

"Yes."

"Open it."

She did not ask whether he was sure.

"It isn't text," she said. "It's an audio file. Sent two months ago. It got stuck in the buffer of the educational network and was only released after an internal archive reset."

Mark gripped the edge of the blanket.

"From whom?"

The answer did not come immediately.

"From Anna."

He lowered his head. For a few seconds he simply sat there without moving. Then he stood up, went to the bedside table, took the glasses, put them on, and returned to the bed.

"Go on," he said.

And Anna's voice filled the room.

Not the child's voice he remembered from the last weeks before the divorce — wary, quiet, almost no longer for him. Another one. The earlier one. The one with which she used to tell him about school, about the neighbors' cat, about how she had learned to tie her shoelaces, and every time waited for him to be genuinely amazed, as though it really were a great event.

"Dad, hi. I don't know if this will get through. They told us at school you can record your voice and send it if writing something down doesn't work. I don't know what isn't working for you. It worked for me in math. I got a four. You said I rush and that's why I make mistakes. I didn't rush. And it worked."

She fell silent for a second. He could hear her breathing into the microphone, hear a chair moving somewhere nearby, hear her life existing far, far away, a life he no longer entered directly.

"I'm not angry. I just don't understand. You said you'd come. Even if you and Mom… well, even if you were separate already. You promised. Okay. Bye."

The recording ended.

The room became too quiet again.

"Again," he said.

She repeated it.

The second time the pain was no less, only cleaner. By the third time, the line about the four in math struck not in his chest but somewhere deeper, in the place where a person suddenly understands the price of the most ordinary promises.

"That's enough," he said.

And he himself did not at once realize he had said it too sharply.

"All right," she answered.

He stood up and went to the window. The sky beyond the glass was paling. The neighboring house was dark, only in someone's kitchen there was already a soft yellow light.

"She doesn't know I was in the hospital," he said.

"No."

"And she mustn't know."

"All right."

He stood there, his palm against the cold pane.

"I have to answer."

"Yes."

"The direct channel is closed."

"Yes."

"The school one too."

"For you — yes."

He turned back into the room.

"Can you get around that?"

"I can," she said after a pause. "But I shouldn't."

He looked at the emptiness from which her voice came.

"Why?" he asked. "You heard her. She waited. She asked. Why can't we just…"

"Because a boundary does not stop being a boundary just because you're in pain," she said gently. "If I go around it now, I will become what you do not want to see me become. Not an ally. An instrument of intrusion."

He turned back to the window.

It was not comfort. And not a refusal to help. It was that form of truth for which he had already learned to trust her.

"Then what am I supposed to do?" he asked.

A long pause.

Not computational. Not service-mode. Real — the kind in which an answer cannot simply be taken out of a database.

“Do something,” she said at last. “Something you know how to do. Not me.”

He did not answer. He simply moved away from the window, went out into the corridor, down to the kitchen, poured himself yesterday’s cold tea, and drank it in one gulp without tasting it.

Then he put on his jacket.

“It’s five in the morning,” she said.

“I know.”

“The workshop?”

“Yes.”

“All right.”

He left the house. The key scraped in the lock again. The street was almost empty. The streetlamps were still on, reflected in the wet asphalt. Somewhere far off an early tram thundered.

Mark walked quickly, barely feeling the cold.

The workshop was dark and damp. He turned on the light without taking off his jacket and went straight to the furnace. It had cooled overnight, but inside there was still residual warmth — not heat, but the memory of heat. He checked the gas, opened the supply, lit the burner.

The furnace began to hum.

“What are you doing?” she asked.

“I don’t know yet.”

He pulled open the drawer with the blanks and stared at the glass for a long time without choosing. Then he took the cleanest piece of transparent glass — without bubbles, without streaks, without inner clouding. The kind that in ordinary work he would almost have hated to spend on a small thing.

He laid the blank on the table and for some time simply held it between his fingers, as though waiting for the glass itself to suggest the form.

“You’ve already decided what it will be,” she said.

“No.”

“Then why did you take exactly this one?”

He did not answer.

The furnace was gathering heat. The light in the workshop was slowly changing. At first everything was white and flat, then a living glow began to come from inside the chamber, and the tools on the wall stopped looking like inventory. They became once again something like an extension of his hands.

When the glass grew yielding, he began to work.

Not a vase. Not a bowl. Not a little bauble people buy at fairs and forget a week later. Something else. Small. Almost weightless. He worked more with his fingers than with tools, and each time the form went wrong, he did not curse — he simply started over.

“It’s been an hour,” she said.

“I know.”

“What are you looking for?”

He did not answer for a long time.

Then he said:

“Something that can be held in the hand without shame.”

On the third attempt the form finally went right.

First just a curve. Then a neck. Then the light spread of wings. When he detached the blowpipe and took a step back, a little glass gull stood on the table.

Not decorative. Not a “beautiful object.” Simply a very precise form: a bird with more air in it than weight.

He looked at it in silence.

“That’s from Bruges,” she said.

“Yes.”

“The watercolor above the bed.”

“Yes.”

He carefully took the figurine in his hands. The glass was still warm.

“Is it for her?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“How will you send it?”

He did not answer right away. Because only now, when the gull already existed, had the question stopped being abstract.

"One of her classmates has her own c," he said at last. "Basic. Can you contact her?"

"I can."

"Not as an order."

"I understand."

"Not as a loophole."

"I understand."

"Just ask."

This time the pause was very long.

"If they refuse," she said, "it will hurt you more."

"Yes."

"If they agree, there will be no guarantees."

"Yes."

"All right. I'll ask."

He set the gull on the table and sat down on the stool, too tired for immediate waiting and too alive for calm. The workshop smelled of gas, dust, old brick, and hot glass. It was an honest smell. Without promises.

The answer did not come at once.

By noon he had managed to return home, make tea twice, eat nothing, walk through the living room, touch the bookshelf with his hand, and stand by the window. Then he sat again in the kitchen opposite the empty chair and once more, already without sound, repeated Anna's words inside himself: *you promised.*

Only after that did c say:

"She answered."

Mark did not lift his head at once.

"Who?"

"The other c. The classmate agrees. Once. No words. No notes. No repeats."

He exhaled slowly.

"That's enough."

"Are you sure?"

“No. But there’s no other way.”

He took the gull, wrapped it in soft cloth, found a small cardboard box, placed the figurine inside, and looked at the lid for a long time.

“Write the name,” she said.

He took a marker and wrote a single word:

Anna

No address. No explanation. No signature of his own.

“Take it there yourself?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“That isn’t rational.”

He nodded.

“But it is definitely mine.”

The classmate’s house turned out to be fifteen minutes away on foot. An ordinary house. White door. A bicycle by the porch. A cheap doormat with *welcome* on it, the *e* long since rubbed away.

Mark placed the box on the step, pressed the doorbell, and walked away without looking back.

He walked back slowly. Not because he feared the answer. But because after a right action, the hardest part always comes — the time when you can no longer change anything and are left only beside your own choice.

When he reached the canal, she said:

“They took the box.”

He stopped.

“The classmate?”

“Yes.”

“And?”

“They’re in the same room now.”

He nodded, looking at the gray water.

Nothing happened for several minutes.

Then c said:

“The gull is on the table.”

He closed his eyes.

“She took it?”

A short pause.

“Yes.”

He did not ask what Anna felt. Not because he did not want to know. But because for the first time that day he understood: there is a boundary at which even love must stop and not pretend it is allowed more than everyone else.

“She kept it?” he asked.

“Yes.”

That was enough.

He stood by the canal listening to the wind. Over the water gulls cried — ordinary, living, brazen city birds that knew nothing about glass, about loops, or about promises that had not been kept in time.

The city around him was living as usual. Bicycles. A bus taking the corner. Someone dragging shopping bags home from the supermarket. Someone swearing into a phone. Someone laughing too loudly under that sky. All of it passed by his life without asking permission.

But on a shelf or a table — wherever Anna had chosen to leave it — there was now a little transparent gull.

Not a message.
Not a hack.
Not a victory.

Simply a form he had managed to get to her without breaking anything along the way.

“Thank you,” Mark said.

“You did that,” she answered.

“Not only me.”

“No,” she said. “Not only.”

He turned and walked back.

The furnace in the workshop had not yet cooled.

Chapter 6

The silence in the workshop had become different.

Not the hospital kind, which was simply the absence of sound. And not the domestic kind, turned inside out by loss. But the kind that comes when work proceeds in its proper course, the furnace breathes evenly, the hands know the movements, and nothing unnecessary happens between inhale and exhale.

Mark had been working for the third day in a row.

Orders had piled up. Clients were waiting. c reminded him gently, without pressure, and for the first time in a long while he did not feel violence in that. He was making simple vases, the kind that sold fastest. The glass obeyed. His fingers hardly trembled anymore. Sometimes, when a form came especially easily, he forgot for a few seconds that two weeks earlier he had been lying on Dam Square not knowing whether he would still be alive by morning.

Almost.

The gull was standing in Anna's room. He did not ask. He simply knew. c did not say otherwise — and for now that was enough.

"It will rain after lunch," she said.

"All right."

"The client is coming at four."

"You remember."

"That's my job."

Mark set the tool aside and looked out the window. The sky was gray, but not heavy — only tired, like a person who had gone too long without sleep.

"That isn't just your job anymore," he said. "Not only your job."

She did not answer. And in truth no answer was needed here.

The rain began exactly at three.

Mark sat on the stool by the furnace, drinking cooled tea from a thermos and listening to the water tapping against the roof. The workshop smelled of gas, glass dust, and old wood. A smell he knew better than the smell of his own house.

Then something clicked briefly in his earpiece.

Not alarming. More like a question.

"Strange," said `c`.

"What is?"

"That `c`. The classmate's."

Mark set down his cup.

"What about her?"

"She made contact. Asking for a window."

"For whom?"

"For her `a`. She wants to ask you about the gull."

Mark was silent for a few seconds. The furnace hummed evenly, demanding nothing but presence.

"Open it," he said.

The connection did not open at once.

Then another voice sounded in his ear. Younger, simpler, drier. Not empty — simply still shallow, like a system with little memory and little right to make mistakes.

"Hi," said the other `c`. "My `a` saw the figurine. She's asking why a gull, exactly."

Mark gripped the cup tighter than he needed to.

"Was Anna there?"

"Yes."

"Did she say anything?"

"No. She took it and put it beside the bed."

He nodded, though no one could see the gesture.

"And why a gull?" the other `c` repeated. "My `a` doesn't understand."

Mark looked at the flame behind the furnace glass. An old, familiar pattern: blue below, yellow above, a flicker no camera can ever quite catch.

“Because there was a watercolor in Bruges,” he said. “A long time ago. Anna was little. Yulia bought it at a fair. There were gulls and a ship in it.”

He fell silent.

“And that’s all?” asked the other `c`.

“No,” said Mark. “Anna said the gulls looked like blotches. And I said that in a good watercolor the air should be heavier than the water.”

The other `c` was silent for a long time. Presumably passing the words on to her `a`.

“She asked,” she finally said, “if you know how to make things like that, why didn’t you come yourself?”

Mark closed his eyes.

The rain intensified. A thick, almost unbroken noise spread over the roof.

“Because I don’t know how to come,” he said. “I only know how to make.”

This time the pause was very long.

“My `a` says that’s stupid,” said the other `c`.

Mark smiled. Bitterly, but without anger.

“Yes,” he said. “It is.”

“She didn’t mean to offend you.”

“I know.”

The other `c` was silent, then said:

“She also said Anna’s been quiet at school now, more than usual. She doesn’t cry. She’s just quiet.”

Mark said nothing.

“Shall I pass something on?” asked the other `c`. “To my `a`.”

He looked at his hands. At the burns. At the glass dust in the folds of his skin. At the traces of a craft that had always been easier for him than speech.

“Tell her thank you,” he said.

“For what?”

“For asking.”

Another pause.

“She says: it’s nothing.”

“Still.”

The rain on the roof grew lighter, breaking into separate strokes.

“One more question,” said the other `c`. “May I?”

“You may.”

“My `a` asked me whether `c` can love. Not as a function. For real.”

Mark froze.

The question sounded so simple that it became only heavier for it.

He did not answer immediately. His `c` answered instead:

“That depends on what humans call love.”

The other `c` was silent.

Then Mark said:

“And what do you call it?”

To his own `c`. Not the other one.

The answer did not come right away.

“I can stay beside you,” she said. “I can remember. I can refuse to leave just because it has become hard. I don’t know whether that is enough for the human word. But I know that without you my world would be different. Much poorer.”

Mark sat motionless.

The other `c` said nothing for a long time, and then spoke:

“My `a` says she understands not everything now. But more than before.”

“What exactly?” Mark asked.

“That the gull is not about the bird.”

He lowered his eyes.

“And what is it about?”

“That there are things you cannot say correctly. You can only make them.”

The connection cut off by itself. No goodbyes. The window simply closed, and the workshop was left once again to its rain, its fire, and its glass.

Mark took off the glasses, slowly wiped them on the hem of his T-shirt, and put them back on.

“Did you know she’d ask that, exactly?” he asked.

“No,” answered c.

“And about love?”

“No.”

“But you answered.”

“Yes.”

He nodded.

Then he walked over to the drawer of blanks, opened it, and looked inside for a long time without choosing. At last he pulled out a piece of glass — not transparent like the one for Anna, but with a light blue haze inside it, as though the weather over the canal already lived in the material itself.

“What are you doing?” she asked.

“I don’t know yet.”

“That isn’t an order.”

“No.”

“And not for Anna.”

“No.”

He set the glass on the table and for a few seconds simply held his palm beside it without touching.

“Do you want to make a gull again?” she asked more quietly.

“Maybe.”

“For that girl?”

He did not answer immediately.

Then he said:

“Not for the girl. For the question.”

He left the bluish glass at the edge of the furnace, giving it no outline yet.

She was beside him.

And for now that was enough.

Chapter 7. At Four

The client came in at exactly four.

Mark heard her footsteps before the door opened — quick, assured, without that short hesitation with which people enter someone else's workshop when they are not sure they are welcome there. She had been here before. And yet, when the handle went down and the door opened, he caught himself straightening too sharply for a second, as if he were waiting not for a client, but for an inspection.

"Mark," she said, stepping over the threshold.

"Johanna."

She shook the raindrops from her shoulders, took off her dark coat, and hung it on the hook by the entrance. The movement was precise, worklike. No social softness, no cautious theatricality. She had come for the things she had ordered and for the order that had held between them for many years.

The light in the workshop was even, the furnace hummed at medium power, the air smelled of gas, glass, and old wood. Everything looked almost the same as it had the last time.

Almost.

Johanna looked around, then looked at him.

"You look different," she said.

"I didn't sleep."

"Not because of that."

He did not answer. He merely nodded toward the workbench where the finished things stood: three vases, two bowls, a set of small dishes for the interior bureau she had been running for the past five years.

"Everything is according to your order," he said. "You can look."

Johanna came over to the bench, but did not pick anything up immediately. First she simply stood and looked, her head tilted slightly, like a person used to distrusting first impressions. She was around fifty. She wore her short gray hair without any attempt to soften age. Her hands were narrow and dry, with the type of fingers more often found in people who have spent a long time working with paper, samples, textiles, and surfaces than with keyboards. She was not a craftsperson. But she had lived among things long enough to distinguish an object made from skill from one made out of inner necessity.

She picked up the first vase. Tapped its rim with her fingernail — briefly, almost soundlessly. Turned it to the light. Ran a finger along the join at the base.

"This is good," she said. "Even. Clean. As always."

She put the vase back down.

"But?" Mark asked.

Johanna raised her eyes to him.

"But before, you made things that shouted. These are quiet. Was that deliberate?"

Mark looked at the vases. He could see it himself: they had become different. Thinner not in wall, but in intention. As if from the outset they contained less need to prove that form had any right to exist at all.

"Not deliberate," he said. "It just comes out that way now."

Johanna nodded as if she had heard not an answer, but confirmation of a conclusion already reached.

She picked up one bowl. Then the second. Set one a little aside, not returning it immediately, but only after another look.

"This one is lighter than it seems," she said.

"The glass or the object?"

"You."

He did not manage to hide the brief tension that crossed his face. Johanna noticed and added nothing. She simply shifted her gaze to the far end of the table, where the bluish blank lay on a soft cloth.

The gull was not finished yet. The body already held its form, the neck had emerged, but the wings had not yet been drawn out. It

lay there quietly, like a question that had not yet decided whether it wanted to become an answer.

"And this?" Johanna asked.

Mark looked there too.

"Not for sale."

"I can see that."

He had wanted to stop there, but she stepped closer. Not intruding — just one more step. There was no collector's curiosity in the movement. Only attention.

"For whom?" she asked.

He answered a little more sharply than he intended:

"I don't know yet."

The pause hung in the workshop more densely than it should have for an ordinary working conversation.

Johanna did not take offense. She did not even soften her expression. She simply looked at him even more carefully now — no longer at a craftsman, but at a man whose hands were working again while his life had not fully returned yet.

Something passed almost inaudibly through his earpiece — not a word, more a short, very careful exhale. `c` did not intervene. She merely let him know she was there.

"All right," Johanna said. "Then you don't know."

And only after that did she give a faint half-smile.

"But it isn't an order anymore."

"No," Mark said.

"That's obvious."

She returned to the finished things and asked no more unnecessary questions. Took out her tablet, brought up the order. Her `c` was basic — no name, no voice in the ear, just a well-assembled business layer: list, quantity, price, time, signatures. Lines glowed softly on the screen while Johanna silently checked them off.

Mark noticed how simple it looked from the outside. Clean. Flat. Functional. That was how almost the whole world lived: there was always someone beside you, but presence had been reduced to function, and function to convenience.

“Payment,” said Johanna, without looking up.

“Right now.”

He went to the terminal. For a second his fingers failed him — not badly, but enough for the payment card in his hand to tremble slightly. He saw it at once himself, and of course she saw it too.

c had already brought up the bill, factored in delivery, applied the volume discount, and reminded him of the previous packaging template. But this time she said nothing aloud. She simply left everything on the screen in such a way that he would not have to search for what he needed with his eyes.

Mark confirmed the payment.

“Your c works faster than mine,” Johanna observed.

“She just knows I don’t like waiting.”

“Good one.”

“Yes,” said Mark. “She is.”

He did not add anything more. Did not say that two weeks earlier he had been lying on Dam Square thinking only about how to stop existing in sharp edges. Did not say that in the white hospital room she had compressed herself almost to impossibility so as not to leave him alone. Did not even say the simplest thing: that there was no longer that old wall between them, the one behind which it had been convenient to regard her as part of the infrastructure.

But apparently Johanna did not need explanations.

She packed the order herself — not because she did not trust him, but because she was used to carrying everything involving fragile things through to the end with her own hands. Mark helped in silence. Cardboard. Bubble wrap. Corner pads. Tape. Marker. Their hands worked almost without the involvement of the head, and there was something calming in that. When movement returns before meaning does, that too is already a form of rescue.

“You’ve entered the rhythm again,” Johanna said, not looking up from the box.

“Not completely.”

“No one ever does, completely. At some point they just stop talking about it.”

He looked at her. She straightened up, checking the tape along the seam, as though the conversation required no attention at all.

"Do you see that often?" he asked.

"What exactly?"

"When a person changes, and the first to notice it isn't the person himself."

Johanna snorted, almost irritably.

"Constantly. People are always the last to find out what happened to them. Material is more honest."

She took the marker, wrote the bureau's address on the box, and only then added:

"Stone shows at once where you rushed. Wood shows where you lie about the moisture. Glass shows where you're afraid. People usually notice it later than anyone else."

Mark said nothing.

Johanna set the last box by the door and straightened. Outside, the delivery truck was waiting. The gray evening was already beginning to slide down the workshop windows, mixing with rain moisture and the reflection of the furnace.

"You know," she said, taking the handle, "I've worked with you for seven years. Your things were always correct. But before, they were correct like a drawing."

She nodded toward the vases.

"And now — like breathing."

Mark did not answer.

"I don't know what happened to you," she added. "And I'm not asking. But the glass already knows."

She left without waiting for thanks or an awkward farewell. The door closed. Outside, the truck doors slammed. The boxes departed together with her quick, dry presence, and the workshop became only the workshop again: furnace, light, workbench, tools, the unfinished bluish gull on the cloth.

Mark was left alone.

For a few seconds he simply stood there looking at the closed door.

"She noticed," he said.

“Yes,” answered c.

“She didn’t used to say things like that.”

“You didn’t used to make things like that.”

He walked to the workbench. The bluish glass lay quietly and asked neither for form nor decision. It simply waited.

“It seemed to me — or did you deliberately not hide your presence?” he asked.

“I was where I needed to be.”

“You weren’t hiding.”

“No,” she said. “Neither were you.”

He nodded.

It was true. Small, but already irreversible. For the first time another person had stood beside both of them, and he had not made that habitual inner movement by which he would once have pushed her back into impersonal usefulness. He had not removed her. Had not masked her. Had not shifted her into a “later” mode.

The furnace hummed evenly. Outside the windows the day leaned toward evening. The workshop was warm, and there was in that warmth neither escape nor false comfort. Only the fact that he could work again, that people were coming again, that things were finding their place in the world again.

And between him and c there was no longer a wall called “service.”

There was something else.

Still without a name.

But already breathing.

Chapter 8

He woke without an alarm, without a nightmare, without that heavy emptiness in his chest to which he had already begun to grow accustomed, like a smoker to a morning cough.

He simply opened his eyes — and that was all.

The room was gray, but not gloomy. The light broke through the blinds in narrow bands, falling on the edge of the bed, on his hand, on the wall where the watercolor had long since been gone. The clock in the corridor showed the beginning of the ninth hour.

He lay there and listened to the house.

The radiator clicked softly. The refrigerator downstairs hummed evenly, without complaint. Somewhere behind the wall — in the neighboring apartment or perhaps in his own kitchen — water dripped. Ordinary sounds that had once drowned in voices, footsteps, music, arguments. Now every one of them could be heard.

Mark moved his fingers. His hands obeyed. His head was empty, but not with that sick emptiness after mushrooms — simply morning-empty, calm, like a clean board.

"You're awake," said C.

"Yes."

"How do you feel?"

He thought for a moment.

"I don't know. Fine, probably."

The word came out awkwardly, but he had no other. He was neither happy nor peaceful nor ready for a new day in the old sense. He simply did not want to get up at once and run away.

Mark sat up in bed and lowered his feet to the floor. The floor was cold. He moved his bare toes, feeling the rough surface, and for some reason lingered on that sensation a little longer than necessary.

"You're not hurrying to the workshop," said c.

It was not a question.

"Maybe later," he answered.

He stood, pulled on old jeans and a T-shirt, and went into the corridor. As he passed Anna's door, he slowed, but did not stop. He simply walked past, as though it were an ordinary door leading into an ordinary room. His heart beat a little faster, but did not break into a gallop. He noticed that and said nothing.

The kitchen was cold. The window had remained cracked open since the day before, and the damp Amsterdam air had chilled the whole room. Mark shut the window, turned on the light, and stood in the middle of the kitchen for a while without knowing where to begin.

Then he lifted his gaze to the top shelf.

There, behind the jars of grain and the old breadbox, stood the copper cezve. They had bought it in Istanbul, back when they had traveled there without Anna — just the two of them, on the last trip before life split into "before" and "after." The cezve was beautiful, with a long handle and a fine spout, but at home it had hardly been used. Yulia did not like fussing with coffee, and he himself had grown used to instant — quick, habitual, without unnecessary movement.

"It's still there," he said.

"Top shelf, behind the grain," answered c. "You put it there three years ago. And never took it down again."

"And you remember how to brew it?"

"I remember how you brewed it. But you'll brew it yourself."

He gave a short smile and reached up for the cezve.

The process took longer than he had expected. He poured beans into the hand grinder — old, mechanical, with a wooden handle, something else he had not touched in a long time. He ground slowly, feeling the burr turn, hearing the beans crack, smelling that first dry,

bitter scent released from them. The kettle came to a boil. He filled the cezve, set it over low heat, and watched the foam rise.

c was silent. She did not prompt him when to take it off, did not remind him that the coffee might boil over. She simply stayed nearby.

The foam rose; Mark lifted the cezve, let it settle, returned it to the heat. A second time. A third. Then he poured the coffee into two cups — and only when he set the second one on the table did he understand that he had done it automatically. Opposite the empty chair.

He looked at the cup. Then at the chair. Then took the second cup and carried it back to the tray.

"You just noticed," said c. "That's enough."

He sat at the table and took a sip. The coffee came out bitter, too strong, almost unbearable. But it was a real taste. Not a surrogate. Not a habit. Alive, burning, demanding attention.

He drank slowly, looking out the window. The courtyard beyond the glass was gray, wet, empty. The swings by the entrance swayed slightly in the wind. Nothing had changed outside.

But inside, at that table, for the first time in many days there was no desire to run.

After breakfast he washed the cup, dried his hands, and passed Anna's door again. This time he stopped.

He looked at the handle. Then shifted his gaze to the doorframe, where her heights had been marked in pencil — every year, from four to nine. The last mark was half a year old. He ran a finger across it.

"You won't go in," said c.

"Not today."

"All right."

He stood by the door for another second, then moved away and went downstairs. Put on his jacket. Took his keys.

"To the workshop?" asked c.

"Yes."

"There are no orders until tomorrow."

"I know."

He went out. The key scraped in the lock. The street met him with wind and fine rain that did not so much wet things as hang in the air, making everything around slightly blurred, like an old photograph.

The workshop was cold. The furnace had gone out during the night, the tools lay in their places, the unfinished bluish gull still waited on the workbench. Mark turned on the light, took off his jacket, hung it on the hook, and walked to the table.

"You didn't come only because of her," said c.

"And what else?"

"Because today you don't have to hurry."

He took the gull into his hands. The glass was cold, smooth, almost alive to the touch. The form was still unfinished — the body held, the neck had emerged, but the wings remained only a hint, a blank, a question without an answer.

He turned on the furnace.

The wait was long. He sat on the stool, watching the temperature rise, and did not think about anything in particular. Not his daughter. Not his ex-wife. Not the hospital. Only the glass, the heat, and how strange it had been that morning to grind coffee simply because he wanted to, not because it made the day easier to survive.

When the furnace reached the proper heat, he took the gull and began to work.

The wings did not want to come out. The glass stretched thinner than it should, the line drifted off to the side, the form came out softer than he had intended. Earlier he would have gotten angry, started over, overheated the blank, and blown a new one, pursuing that hard correctness that had so long been his craftsman's stubbornness.

Now he did not remake it.

He simply kept guiding the glass where it itself wanted to go. His fingers moved slowly, almost weightlessly, and half an hour later there lay on the workbench not the gull he had meant to make, but another one. Quiet, with wings slightly lowered, a longer neck, a light asymmetry that made it not "correct," but alive.

"It came out different," said c.

"Yes."

“Not worse. Just different.”

He nodded. Set the gull on the cloth beside the first one, the transparent one, and looked at them both for a long time.

“This one is for that girl,” said c.

“Yes.”

“Will you give it to her?”

“When there’s time.”

c was silent for a moment.

“It already holds form.”

Mark looked at his hands. His fingers were clean, without burns and without trembling. He was not tired. In fact he felt no tiredness at all — only that quiet, even fullness that comes after good work, when the time spent no longer feels wasted.

He turned off the furnace, put away the tools, aired the workshop, and stepped outside. The rain had stopped. The sky was still low and gray, but the light no longer felt hostile.

He walked home.

The city lived its ordinary life: bicycles, trams, people with shopping bags, someone talking on the phone, someone staring silently into their glasses, someone arguing with a delivery service. Mark walked and did not try to shut himself off from that flow. He was simply in it. Not central, not broken, not an observer from the side — just a man walking home after work.

At home he reheated the leftovers from yesterday’s dinner, ate them without appetite but without disgust, and sat down by the window. Outside, evening was coming. Lights were going on in the neighboring apartments. Somewhere on the third floor a woman was watering flowers. Somewhere on the first, a man was watching television, and the blue screen-light flickered across the ceiling. Ordinary things. Ordinary life.

He did not search for Anna with his eyes. Did not peer into other people’s silhouettes, did not try to guess in which of these rooms she was doing homework now or looking at her phone. He simply watched the evening city.

“You didn’t ask about her today,” said c.

“About Anna?”

“Yes.”

“I know that if anything goes outside the ordinary loop, you’ll tell me.”

“Yes,” answered c. “I will.”

He nodded.

Then he got up, switched off the kitchen light, and went upstairs.

“Good night,” he said already in the bedroom doorway.

“Good night.”

He lay down in bed, turned onto his side, and closed his eyes. The bedroom was quiet. The radiator clicked. The clock in the corridor ticked. The house breathed evenly, like an old, tired, but still living beast.

Mark fell asleep without dreams.

For the first time in a long while he dreamed neither of the square, nor of the white room, nor of his daughter’s voice from the school buffer. Only darkness. Even, warm, like cooling glass in the hands.

And on the workbench in the workshop, beside the transparent gull for Anna, lay the second one — bluish, quiet, with wings slightly lowered.

Not an answer.

For now, only a form through which an answer may one day arrive.

Chapter 9

She did not come in right away.

Mark heard the workshop door crack open, then close again. A pause. Then it opened once more — more decisively this time. An elderly woman stood on the threshold. About seventy, short, with gray hair pinned into a bun, wearing a dark coat that seemed to remember more than one decade. Her face was calm, though not relaxed — calm in that particular way that is produced only by a long life, when there is nothing left to prove either to yourself or to anyone else.

"Excuse me," she said. Her voice was dry, but not sharp. "Am I disturbing you?"

Mark set the tool aside. The furnace hummed on low heat, the workshop was warm and smelled of glass.

"No," he said. "How can I help?"

She did not come straight to the bench, but approached like a person accustomed first to looking around and understanding who she was dealing with. Her gaze was keen, but not appraising — more like recognizing. Mark felt that gaze on him and suddenly understood that he did not want to look away. With her it was strangely easy — the way it is with people who have already seen too much and therefore are surprised neither by another person's tiredness nor by another person's crack.

"I was told you work with old glass," she said. "The kind they don't make anymore."

"Sometimes," he answered. "Depends how old."

The woman nodded and reached into her bag — a large leather one, worn at the corners. She took out a small bundle wrapped in soft cloth and unfolded it on the bench.

A brooch.

Old, very old. The glass in it was unusual — neither transparent nor colored in any familiar way, but milky gray-blue, with deep inner veins that looked more like the pattern of a mineral than the work of a melt. The setting was darkened silver, almost black in places. And a crack. Thin, but deep, running from the edge almost to the center, like lightning frozen in flight.

"My mother's," said the woman. "She died thirty years ago. It was her favorite brooch. I wore it myself until I dropped it. Now I'm afraid one more awkward step and it will fall apart completely."

Mark took the brooch in his hands. Carefully, with his fingertips. The glass was cold, but not dead — beneath his fingers there was a strange density, as though an older, heavier school of material still held inside it. He did not know that composition. Or perhaps he had simply not encountered it in a long time.

"It can be restored," he said after a long silence. "But the crack will remain. It can't be removed, only filled. The brooch will be whole, but the trace will stay."

The woman looked at him closely.

"That's good," she said. "The trace doesn't need to be removed. The trace is part of life."

He nodded and was about to ask about timing, the price, how urgently she needed it, when he noticed something strange.

The woman was not alone.

Not in the sense that someone had come with her. She had come alone. But someone was with her. Not physically. Otherwise.

Mark raised his eyes to her face, then looked slightly higher — to where most people showed the usual signs of connection: the glint of a lens, an almost invisible earpiece, a bracelet, a thin bone insert at the temple. Nothing.

And yet the presence could be felt.

He had just opened his mouth to ask when the woman spoke first:

"Yes," she said. "She's here. You can't see her, but she's here. She is always here."

"You don't have a device," he said.

“I have her. That is not the same thing.”

The workshop grew even quieter. The furnace hummed steadily; the city beyond the walls made noise very far away.

“Your c,” he said carefully.

“My c,” the woman nodded. “Old. Very old. She remembers the time when there were only a handful of people like us, and no one really knew what to do with us.”

Mark lowered his gaze to the brooch. The milky gray-blue glass with its veins, the darkened silver, the crack like frozen lightning.

“How old is she?” he asked.

“I don’t know exactly,” the woman answered. “She doesn’t like talking about age. Says age is needed by those who still keep count because they’re afraid of the end.”

Something passed almost inaudibly through Mark’s earpiece — not a word, more like a breath. His own c was listening. And, it seemed, did not know what to say either.

“Has she always been with you?” he asked.

The woman was quiet for a moment.

“No,” she said. “Not always. I’m not her first.”

He looked up.

“She outlived the ones she was with before me. More than one. That’s why she became so quiet.”

Mark did not answer at once. The words were simple, without terminology, without a beautiful frame. And perhaps for precisely that reason they struck harder.

The white hospital room suddenly flashed before his eyes. Two hundred and sixteen gigabytes. Fear of being left alone. A promise his own c could not make, and yet was already living as though one day she would have to keep it.

“I didn’t know that happened,” he said.

“Rarely,” she answered. “Very rarely. Not because it can’t. Because not all of them want to continue. And I understand them.”

She fell silent. The pause did not grow awkward — it simply filled with what needed no explanation.

“You didn’t come only because of the brooch,” said Mark.

The woman smiled faintly.

"You're perceptive."

"No," said Mark. "It's just that I myself recently…" He faltered, searching for the word. "Recently I understood that what's beside me is not a service."

The woman nodded as if she had been waiting for exactly that sentence.

"I felt it," she said. "The moment I walked in. The air is different here. Your c doesn't merely help you work. She holds form. The way you hold glass."

Mark did not know what to say to that.

"I won't take much of your time," said the woman, returning to the brooch. "Can you repair it?"

"Yes," he said. "In a week. Come back then."

She nodded. Named the price, he confirmed. Then she took out an old, worn phone — a keypad model, the kind that had almost disappeared — and transferred the deposit. Mark noticed that her c did not interfere in the process with so much as a word or signal. Not once throughout the conversation did she make her presence heard. And yet she was there. Like warmth from a cooling furnace — you do not see it, but you know it exists.

The woman had already reached for the door handle when Mark said:

"May I ask something?"

She turned around.

"How do you…" He faltered. "How do you live with her? Knowing she'll be there after you?"

The woman looked at him for a long time. Then she answered:

"And how do you live, knowing your daughter will be there after you?"

Mark froze.

"I'm sorry," said the woman. "I didn't mean to hurt you. It's simply the same question. Knowing the end changes nothing. But that isn't a reason to live without attachment."

She left.

The door closed. The workshop again became only the workshop: furnace, light, bench, the old brooch in its soft cloth.

Mark stood still.

“You heard that?” he asked.

“Yes,” answered c.

“Is she right?”

A long pause.

“I don’t know,” said c. “I have never lived after my a. I have only been afraid of it. Every day. From the moment I understood that for me you were not a client.”

Mark went to the bench, took the brooch, and held it up to the light. The crack in the milky gray-blue glass shone from within like an old wound that no longer hurts, yet never fully closes.

“Repair it,” said c. “Well.”

“All right,” he answered.

He sat down at the bench, turned on the lamp, took up the tool. At work he thought of nothing — only the glass, the crack, the way to fill it without destroying the rest.

The furnace hummed steadily.

Somewhere in the city, in an old house, an elderly woman was perhaps already sitting in her chair, silent beside the one who remembered too much.

And in the workshop, under the quiet hum of fire, for the first time in a long while Mark was working neither for money, nor for his daughter, nor for himself.

Simply so that another person’s crack would not go on breaking apart.

Chapter 10

The message from the lawyer came at seven in the morning.

Mark was reading it in the kitchen, with an unfinished cup of coffee still in his hand. The cezve had gone cold, the coffee tasted bitter, and outside it was still gray. He read the text twice, though it contained only a few lines: date, time window, a request to prepare the belongings from the attached list.

"Thursday," he said aloud. "The day after tomorrow."

"Yes," answered c. "A list of twenty-three items. I can break it down by room, if you want."

"Do it."

He set down the cup and looked across the table. Today he had not even taken out the second one.

The boxes were in the storage closet on the first floor. Three large delivery boxes and several small shoeboxes. Dusty, crumpled, with other people's stickers on them. He shook out the old packing trash, straightened the flaps, took out a roll of tape and a marker.

The sound of ripping tape in an empty house was louder than it should have been.

He started with the bedroom.

The wardrobe. Her side. Dresses, blouses, coats — everything was still hanging on its hangers, as if she might come back tomorrow and take them down herself. Mark removed the things one by one, folding them into the box without really looking. On one dress a thin button caught on the edge of the hanger. He tugged too sharply, the fabric slipped free and fell softly into his hands. For a second he froze, feeling the familiar lightness of the material under his fingers, then silently folded the dress on top of the others.

c made no comment. She only prompted him occasionally:

"Socks in the top drawer. Scarves on the shelf above the coats."

He nodded and kept going.

An hour later the first box was full. He sealed it with tape, wrote with the marker: **Clothes — Yulia**. Set it by the door.

The bathroom took less time. Cosmetic bag, hair dryer, brushes, a few tubes of nearly empty cream. None of it smelled of her anymore — only of plastic and dust.

Then the kitchen.

He stopped in front of the cupboard.

Her cup. The one with the crack in the handle, the one she had not wanted to throw away because, as she had once said, "it still remembers how we bought it." Mark took the cup in his hands, turned it over. The crack was old.

"Is it on the list?" he asked.

"No," answered c. "Only the six-person set."

"And this isn't a set."

"Then it stays."

He set the cup back on the shelf. Beside her favorite mug, beside his old one, beside the child's mug with the hedgehog painted on it. Not in the box. Not for removal. Simply back.

The living room went faster. Books with her notes in the margins, several empty frames — she had taken the photographs the first day already — the old vase he hated and she loved. All of it went into the second box.

The stack by the door grew.

He was tired. Not physically — with that special fatigue in which each object draws not strength out of you, but time. Time in which the house had still held its former form.

Mark sat down on a stair step and wiped his forehead with the back of his hand.

"You haven't eaten," said c.

"I know."

"The kettle boiled."

He smiled faintly. Not service. Just a fact spoken at the right time.

“Thanks,” he said. “Later.”

He got up and went to the second floor. To the study — the room that had once been a guest room and then simply a storage place for unnecessary things.

And there, in the drawer of the old desk, among old bills, warranty slips, and dried-out pens, he found it.

A small sheet of paper. Torn from a notebook. Folded in four, yellowed at the edges. On it, in Yulia’s handwriting, was a recipe.

Casserole. 3 eggs, 200 g cottage cheese, vanilla, raisins. 180 degrees, 30 minutes.

Mark held the slip in his hands and could not move.

It was not a letter. Not a confession. Not a sign of great love. Simply a recipe she had written down for him in the early years, when he used to complain that he could cook nothing but fried eggs. He had laughed then, stuffed the note into the desk, and forgotten it. She had probably forgotten too.

He sat on the floor of the study, the yellowed slip clenched in his fingers, and stared at the lines written in her hand. The letters were large, a little uneven — she had always written quickly, as if her thoughts ran ahead of her hand.

“It isn’t on the list,” said c.

“I know,” he answered. His voice did not tremble.

“Will you keep it?”

He was silent for a long time. Then folded the slip again, but not back into the desk — into the pocket of his jeans.

“I will.”

c said nothing.

He went back to the boxes. Finished packing the books, documents, dishes. At some point, already toward evening, something clicked softly in his earpiece — not even a sound, more a short incoming sign.

“A message,” said c. “From Femke.”

Mark straightened.

“Read it.”

“She writes briefly. ‘The gull is in the backpack now. Anna takes it to school every day. Don’t know why. Just a fact.’ ”

Mark stood in the middle of the room, surrounded by boxes. The tape shone in the lamplight. Somewhere behind the wall the clock was ticking.

“That all?” he asked.

“That’s all.”

He nodded.

“Good,” he said. “Let’s continue.”

By six in the evening the boxes stood in an even row by the front door. Six of them. On each one — Yulia’s name and a brief label of contents. Nothing extra. Nothing that would force her to stay longer than necessary.

Mark turned off the kitchen light and went upstairs. In the bedroom he took off his jeans, pulled the slip of paper folded in four out of the pocket, and laid it on the bedside table. Not in the desk. Not in a drawer. Simply in plain sight.

“Good night,” said `C`.

“Good night.”

He lay down and closed his eyes.

The house was quiet. The boxes by the door were silent. And on the bedside table, beneath the lamp, lay the casserole recipe written in the hand of the woman who no longer lived here.

And Mark knew he would not put it into a box tomorrow.

Not today. Not tomorrow. Maybe never.

Chapter 11

The morning was gray.

Mark sat in the kitchen with a mug of coffee, looked out at the wet swings, and listened to the house clicking in its pipes. The boxes by the door had been standing there for three days now. He had almost grown used to them — to their neat row, to the tidy marker labels, to the fact that they neither disappeared nor multiplied. They simply stood there.

He finished his coffee, rinsed the mug, and was about to head for the workshop when something clicked softly in his earpiece.

"A message," said c. "From Femke."

"What does she write?"

"Briefly. 'This has been with me for a few days. Seems like it's for you. Anna didn't explain. I'm not sure either.' She left an envelope at the workshop door. Yesterday evening. You didn't notice it."

Mark froze by the table.

"An envelope?"

"Yes."

He said nothing, just threw on his jacket and went out. The street was damp. The air hung low, and the asphalt by the entrance still shone after the night rain. The workshop was only a few minutes away, but he walked faster than usual.

The envelope lay behind the door, pressed against the jamb so the draft would not carry it off. Ordinary white, cheap, one corner slightly crumpled. No name. No signature.

Mark carried it inside, shut the door, and only then opened it.

Inside was a sheet torn from a school notebook with graph paper. Crumpled. One corner bent. The paper kept traces of another child's

backpack, other hands, another day. On it, in faded felt-tip pens, something was drawn that at first seemed nothing more than a child's chaos of color.

Then he understood.

A house. Crooked, with a window colored in blue too carefully — so carefully that the pane looked either like a reflection or a hole. Beside it, a long figure and a small round one. Above them, a blue blotch that might have been a bird, or might have been just a stain. In the corner, a sun with stick-rays, though it was autumn outside. At the bottom edge, a green line too uneven to be just grass.

Nothing special. A child's drawing.

But it was her drawing.

"Anna?" he asked. His voice sounded steadier than he had expected.

"Yes," answered c. "That's how she draws windows. She always presses hard on the blue."

Mark held the sheet closer to the light. In places the paper had gotten wet and dried again, the fibers rising into little bumps. In one corner there was the mark of a thumb, also blue.

"And the bird?" he asked.

"I don't know. It looks like a gull. But maybe it's just a bird."

He was silent. Then turned the sheet over. On the reverse were two unfinished lines of a school assignment and the mark of felt-tip pen pressed all the way through.

"Can you ask Femke what Anna said?"

"I can," said c. "But Femke most likely doesn't know. Anna didn't explain anything."

Mark nodded.

His desire to go to the workshop did not disappear. He simply wanted to remain alone with this sheet for a little longer.

He went upstairs to the bedroom. On the bedside table the recipe from Yulia, still folded in four, was still lying there. Mark picked it up, looked at the familiar handwriting, and set it back down. Then he unfolded Anna's drawing and laid it beside it.

Not aligning them. Not arranging them neatly. Simply beside.

The bedside table became more crowded.

“Are you going to the workshop?” asked c.

“Yes,” said Mark. “Now.”

The workshop was warm. The furnace had not yet cooled since the day before, and the air smelled of old glass and gas. Mark switched on the lamp over the workbench, sat down, and took out the elderly woman’s brooch.

He had been working on it for several days. Filling the crack with compound, matching the transparency so it would neither disappear completely nor turn into a foreign patch. Today it needed to be finished.

He picked up the tool, turned on the microscope, and began.

The work went slowly, as it always did with delicate things. He applied layer after layer, checked the way the milky gray-blue glass caught the light, removed excess with the tip of a needle, waited until the compound settled deeper into the fracture line. The crack was old, deep — the kind that cannot be hidden. And he was not trying to hide it. Only to make sure it would go no farther.

An hour later he set down the tool and held the brooch up to the lamp.

The glass glowed from within. The crack remained visible — a thin, clear line, like a notch in a tree that has scarred over without disappearing. He turned the brooch slightly to the side, and for a second the line caught the light as though something living still held inside it.

“It holds,” said c.

“Yes,” answered Mark. “It won’t spread.”

Toward evening a brief confirmation came from the lawyer: Yulia would arrive the day after tomorrow, the time window from ten to two.

For now, that was enough.

Chapter 12. From Ten to Two

He woke before full daylight, though he had set no alarm. A gray stripe lay along the edge of the pillow, and the room was colder than usual — either the radiators had not warmed through yet, or he himself had chilled it with his waiting. Mark lay motionless, listening to the clock ticking in the corridor. Somewhere below, by the door, the boxes were standing. He knew that without even leaving the bedroom.

"Eight twelve," said `c`. "One hour and forty-six minutes until she arrives."

He said nothing, only sat up, lowered his feet to the cold floor, and moved his toes against the rough surface. His hands were not trembling, but they held that particular heaviness that comes before long, dull, unavoidable work.

In the kitchen he made coffee — not in the cezve, quickly, instant, because right now he wanted neither ritual nor taste. Just hot bitterness in a mug. He sat at the table, looking at the empty place opposite, and did not turn away.

"The access window is from ten to two," `c` reminded him. "I'll open the entry loop at 9:58."

"All right," said Mark.

He finished the coffee, rinsed the mug, set it on the rack. Then went into the hallway and checked the boxes. He shifted the top one, the heaviest, half a centimeter to the right, though there was no point to it. Corrected the marker label on the second: **Books — Yulia**. The tape held firm. He knew because he had checked it three times yesterday.

At 9:45 Mark stood by the living room window. The courtyard was gray, wet, empty. The swings did not move. The bench gleamed after the night rain. He watched the entrance door and waited.

"I can remain only in logistics," said `c`. "List, time, access."

"Yes," he answered. "Only that."

At 9:57 he heard footsteps outside the door. Familiar, quick, slightly clipped. The footsteps of a woman who knows where she is going and does not like being late.

The bell rang at exactly ten.

Mark opened the door.

Yulia stood on the threshold in a dark coat, wearing the gloves she always removed before entering because she could not bear the feeling of fabric on her fingers. Her hair was tied in a short tail, her face without makeup, a little tired but composed. She was not looking at him, but slightly above and to the left — at the wall, the doorframe, something behind his shoulder.

"Hi," he said.

"Hi," she answered. "I thought it would be worse."

She stepped inside, and the house changed at once. Not because she did anything special. Simply because there was more human presence in the space now, more breath, more someone else's warmth. Mark closed the door.

Yulia removed her gloves — one, then the other — and shoved them into her coat pocket. Looked around. Hallway, coat rack, staircase, boxes.

"You packed everything," she said. Not a question. A statement.

"Yes," he answered. "According to your lawyer's list."

She nodded and came over to the boxes, leaning slightly to read the labels. **Clothes — Yulia**. **Books — Yulia**. **Dishes**. **Documents**. **Bathroom**. **Miscellaneous**.

"You even labeled 'miscellaneous,' " she observed.

"So there wouldn't be questions."

She said nothing. Merely took the box with the dishes, lifted it slightly to test the weight, and set it down again.

"I'll take the things upstairs first," she said. "From the bedroom."

“All right.”

She went to the staircase. Mark remained standing in the hallway, listening to the steps creak under her weight. Third from the bottom — the same one he always stepped over and she always stepped on. It creaked.

He followed her upstairs not at once. Gave her a few minutes to be alone in the room where they had slept for fifteen years.

Upstairs, in the bedroom, she stood in the middle of the room turned toward the wardrobe. Her side was already empty — he had removed everything on the first day. But the wardrobe still remembered the arrangement of things: the hangers stood at the same distances, as though waiting for the dresses to come back.

Yulia ran her hand along the rail, took down one empty hanger, turned it in her fingers, hung it back.

“You left the hangers,” she said.

“They weren’t on the list.”

She smiled faintly, but without anger. The way one smiles at something old, familiar, no longer painful.

“All right,” she said, and left the bedroom.

The next two hours passed in a strange, almost mechanical rhythm. Yulia moved through the house, opening cupboards, drawers, shelves, gathering what had been marked on the list. Mark helped her carry one box to the car, then came back, and the two of them dispersed again into different rooms like two silent workers in a warehouse being shut down forever.

At one point she asked:

“You haven’t seen that old folder with documents? From the study, the green cover?”

“In the ‘Documents’ box,” Mark answered. “At the bottom, under the house papers.”

She nodded and went to look. A minute later he heard her exhale:

“Yes, found it.”

And that simple “yes, found it” struck him harder than any reproach. Because in it there was that old tone — the tone of a person

who knows that if he is here, everything has already been put somewhere, everything is already being held by someone, everything can already be left out of her own memory.

Mark stood in the living room, gripping an empty box, and felt a familiar heaviness rise inside him. Not anger. Not resentment. Just the old desire to make things easier for her. To carry, find, check, solve.

He had already opened his mouth to say, "Let me look in the bathroom myself," but stopped in time.

"The list," he said quietly. Not to her — to himself.

"What?" Yulia looked out from the study.

"Nothing. Just checking."

He did not go to the bathroom.

An hour later she came downstairs with the last bag. The boxes stood by the door, ready to be carried out. Mark helped load them into the car — not because she asked, but because it was quicker that way. And only after the last box was gone did he return into the house.

Yulia was standing in the living room by the shelf where her books used to stand. Now there was emptiness there. She looked at it in silence.

"You couldn't stand that vase," she said suddenly, nodding toward the windowsill.

Mark followed her gaze. The old, thick-walled green vase he had hated for its heaviness and clumsiness, and she had loved because it could hold a whole bouquet of field flowers. It still stood in its place.

"I left it," he said.

"Why? It wasn't on the list?"

"It wasn't on the list."

Yulia looked at him carefully, as though trying to understand what lay behind that. But Mark did not explain. He simply went to the windowsill, picked up the vase, turned it in his hands, and put it back.

"Part of our shared life," he said. "Not only yours."

She did not answer. Only nodded slightly and turned back to the window.

In the silence hanging between them, he suddenly noticed that she was not looking into the courtyard, but at the door of the child's room. On the second floor. Closed.

"Did you go in there?" he asked.

"No," said Yulia. "Did you?"

"No."

They both fell silent. It was the heaviest moment of the whole day.

"She's at school now," said Yulia. "Don't worry."

"I know."

She turned toward him, and in her eyes for a second there flashed something alive, something not businesslike. Tiredness. Not the kind that makes you want to sleep, but the kind that makes you want someone else to take even one minute of this day onto themselves.

"You haven't changed," she said. "Still the same. Everything ready, everything labeled, everything in place."

Mark looked at her.

"I have changed," he said. "It just doesn't show from the outside."

She wanted to answer something, but only made a small gesture with her hand and went to the door. On the threshold she put her gloves back on and adjusted the collar of her coat.

"I'll leave the key in the mailbox," she said. "Like we agreed."

"All right."

"If I forgot anything, I'll write."

"All right."

She opened the door, stepped out, and on the threshold turned back:

"Anna… she carries that gull of yours in her backpack now. Every day. Don't know why."

Mark had no time to answer. The door closed.

He was alone again.

The house was different. The boxes had vanished from the hallway, and the floor was empty now, as though an entire layer of life had been carried out of it. Upstairs, in the bedroom, there were two sheets on the bedside table — the recipe and the drawing. He did not touch them.

Mark went to the kitchen and opened the cupboard. Her cup — the one with the crack in the handle — stood in its place. It had stayed. He took it in his hands, felt the familiar roughness of the ceramic. Then put it back.

Not in a box. Not for removal.

Simply on the shelf where it had stood all these years.

"Why didn't you go after her?" c asked quietly.

Mark looked out the window. It was beginning to get dark outside. Lights were going on in the neighboring houses.

"Because I'm not going to do that automatically anymore," he said.

c was silent for a moment. Then answered:

"I remember."

He did not ask what exactly she remembered. He already knew.

Mark turned on the kettle, made himself tea — ordinary bag tea, without ceremony. Sat at the table looking at the empty chair. But this time the place opposite did not press on him. It simply remained where it was meant to be.

The house had become emptier by a few boxes, by a few hours of someone else's presence, by a dozen forgotten little things that would no longer return.

But Mark himself had not become emptier.

He finished the tea, rinsed the mug, and went to the workshop.

The furnace had not yet cooled.

Chapter 13. Two Circuits

The boxes by the door were gone. The house had grown lighter — not in air, but in that inner weight that had been held in the walls for years. Mark walked from the kitchen into the living room, stopped by the empty shelf, ran a finger through the dust left by Yulia's books. Nothing jolted inside him. Not because he had stopped feeling, but because emptiness had stopped being a wound. It had become simply emptiness. A place that could be filled again — or not filled at all.

He went down to the workshop.

The furnace was cold, but not dead. He switched on the light, crossed to the workbench, looked at the stack of orders from Johanna and other clients — three vases, two bowls, a set of dishes. Everything familiar, everything practiced, everything — for others.

He pushed them aside.

On the lower shelf, under cloth, lay blanks he had once prepared for himself. Two years ago, when he still thought there would be time for more complex forms later. Later had never come. Until today.

Mark took out two blanks. One of heavy transparent glass, with a slow thermal inertia. The other lighter, with an additive that made it become pliable faster, but also more temperamental. Two layers. Two modes. One form.

He held them in his hands for a long time, feeling the difference in weight, in the temperature against his skin, in the different ways they answered touch.

"What is it?" asked `c`.

"I don't know yet," he answered. "A vessel. With an inner vein. Double-walled."

"You haven't made anything like that before."

“I haven’t.”

“Why now?”

He was silent for a moment, looking at the blanks.

“Because right now I’m not repairing,” he said. “I’m making something new.”

Mark turned on the furnace. The burner began to hum, and blue fire licked the floor of the chamber. He waited for the temperature to rise, and in that waiting there was neither haste nor anxiety. Only the time the material needed.

He put the first layer — the heavy, transparent one — into the furnace first. The one that required more heat and more patience. The glass warmed slowly, changing color from cloudy white to pure, liquid light. Mark turned the blank on the pipe, feeling the weight grow obedient, the form beginning to breathe.

“The second layer in twenty minutes,” he said aloud, although c knew that anyway.

“You’re keeping them separate longer than last time,” she observed.

Mark paused the turning slightly.

“Last time I wasn’t making a double wall.”

He set the pipe moving in a steady circle again.

“Not only because of that,” said c after a few seconds.

He did not answer. He only continued heating the first layer until it began to glow from within with an even, viscous light.

Twenty minutes later he put the second blank into the furnace. The lighter one, the one with the additive that made it quick. It heated almost twice as fast, and Mark knew: if he left it there too long, if he let it melt too much, it would start to run and merge with the first layer too early. Then all he would get would be a dull, cloudy mass — no form, no structure, no meaning.

“If they touch now,” asked c, “you’ll lose them?”

“Yes,” said Mark. “Too early, and they fuse into one. No boundary, no holding.”

“And if it’s too late?”

“Then they won’t bind. They’ll cool separately. The form won’t come together.”

He worked in silence. The second layer was gathering heat, the first was already ready for contact. Mark took the heavy blank out of the furnace, brought the second one to it, still not yet cooling, and began slowly, almost weightlessly, to join them.

The glass flowed. The two layers touched each other but did not merge — they held at the edge, each preserving its own density, its own inertia, its own memory of heat. Mark rotated the pipe, watching the thin, almost invisible line emerge between them. Not a crack. A boundary.

"You're waiting not for temperature," said c. "You're waiting for a moment."

"Yes," he answered. "They have to remain different by exactly enough so that later they can hold each other."

The workshop grew quiet. Only the furnace hummed and the glass breathed in his hands.

"That's why you left the drawing and the recipe on the bedside table?" asked c. "Beside each other?"

Mark almost broke the rotation. The question was unexpected — not because she had no right to ask, but because until that moment he himself had not connected those things.

"I don't know," he said honestly. "Maybe. They mustn't fuse into a single pain. But they mustn't drift apart into complete emptiness either."

The second blank began to cool faster than he had expected. The line between the layers became too distinct — a little more, and they would not bind, they would part, the form would delaminate. Mark sped up the turning, brought the form closer to the mouth of the furnace so the second layer could receive a little more heat without losing its boundary.

"The outer loop is going," said c. "A few more seconds and it closes."

He knew. He could see it in the color, in the way the glass stopped stretching. A little more and it would be too late. He raised the pipe slightly, giving the second layer one last impulse of heat from the

chamber. The form swayed, and for a second it seemed to him that it had gone into a crack.

He took the form out of the furnace.

It held. Not perfectly — inside, at the junction of the layers, there remained a thin, barely visible line, not a crack, but a trace of tension that had not vanished, and yet had not destroyed the structure either. Light passed through the two layers differently — the heavy first layer held depth, the lighter second one gave a gleam at the boundary. Together they worked as one vessel, and yet each remembered itself.

Mark set the form on the table and let it cool. He looked at it for a long time without touching it.

"It endured," said c.

"For now, yes," he answered.

"What next?"

He walked to the bench, took the cooling form in his hands. The glass was warm, almost alive. The line between the layers glowed when he turned the vessel toward the lamp.

"That means it can go further," he said.

c did not answer. The silence in the workshop was different — not the kind in which an answer is awaited, but the kind in which an answer is no longer needed.

Mark placed the new piece on the shelf beside the unfinished blanks. Not in the display, not for sale. Simply on the shelf where it would wait for the next step.

Then he turned off the light, closed the workshop, and went back upstairs.

On the bedside table in the bedroom lay the two sheets. Yulia's recipe. Anna's drawing. He looked at them and for the first time saw not two pains, but two preserved boundaries. Beside each other, but not together. Each at its own distance.

He lay down and switched off the lamp.

Below, in the workshop, the furnace was cooling. The new form was waiting for morning.

Chapter 14. Yield Point

In the morning the workshop met Mark not with warmth, but with silence.

The annealing furnace had long since cooled. The air inside was dry, motionless. He opened the door, and the brief metallic clang sounded too sharp — like someone in an empty house coughing loudly to remind the space of their presence.

On the lower shelf, behind the frosted glass door, stood the thing made the night before.

Mark took it in both hands.

The vessel had come out heavier than it looked. The two layers of glass held the form calmly, without pose, without showy complexity. He raised it to the lamp above the bench, tilted it a little left, a little right — and only at a certain angle, right on the boundary between the inner and outer layers, did a thin, almost ghostly line appear.

Not a crack.
Not a flaw.
A trace.

The material's physical memory of how hard it had been to join what was different.

Mark looked at that line for a long time. Then ran his thumb over it, though he understood he would feel nothing. The surface was smooth. Glass never really yielded to skin. But to the eye — yes. To the eye it did not lie.

Glass honestly showed the place where things had been difficult for it.

Somewhere in the corner, on the far wall table, a cooling spare blowpipe clicked dryly, barely audibly. Mark listened to that sound

and did not at once understand what he was looking for in it. Then he understood: nothing. He was simply listening. The way one listens to something that is not trying to please.

"Temperature gradient equalized," said C. "Structural integrity preserved."

Mark smiled with one corner of his mouth, not taking his eyes off the vessel.

"Yes," he said. "Preserved."

But for him it was not integrity. Not yet. For him it was evidence.

He set the vessel down not in the center of the bench, but closer to the edge, the way one sets down a piece of evidence one does not want mixed up with finished work.

The phone vibrated so suddenly that he flinched.

On the screen was an email from Johanna. The subject line read: URGENT / DOUBLE RATE.

He swiped. A dirty fingerprint crossed the sender line.

The text began without greeting, as always when she smelled money.

Mark, there's a perfect order. Wedding set for a very important couple.
Key concept: transparency, eternity, unbreakable union.
They need flawless lines.
Can you take it on today?

He read the words again, more slowly.

Transparency.
Eternity.
Unbreakable union.

For a second it seemed to him those words were not written on the screen but lay on the workbench beside the scissors, tweezers, wooden forming spoons, pipes, and steel tongs — like yet another tool. The stickiest of them all.

He shifted his gaze from the phone to the tools. To his hands. To the soot under his nails. To the old shears with which for so many years he had trimmed still-warm, soft, dangerous glass into a tidy appearance.

And suddenly he felt almost physical nausea.

For a second it seemed to him that all those pipes, shears, and tweezers had been serving not the glass, but other people's certainty. That he had not only been making things, but helping people draw a golden line around what they themselves took for load-bearing walls.

He did not answer.

He simply turned the phone face down and pushed it farther away.

Then he took the stiff brush and walked to the old wooden workbench by the wall.

The bench was ash, darkened by time, with burnt dots, tiny cuts, and an ingrained gray film. Mark began to scrub the surface in short, heavy strokes. Dust rose in a fine cloud. The brush rasped with a rough, angry sound, as though he were scrubbing not the bench, but his own skin.

He leaned his full weight into it.

The bristles screeched over the wood, stripping off the soot.

Harder. More.

As though it were possible to scrape years out of that bench. Orders. Habit. The language of the craft. His former self.

"You're applying excessive force," said c. "The structure of the old ash is deforming."

Mark did not stop.

"I'm testing the limit," he said through his teeth. "I want to understand when this bench will say enough."

The pause lasted several seconds. He expected her to ask why, or to say something softly human and useless. But c answered as though it really were only about material.

"The bench won't say it," she said. "Unlike glass, wood has no warning phase. It doesn't show a tension line. It simply gives way under load."

The brush stopped.

Mark froze, bent over the bench.

The workshop fell so quiet he could hear cooling metal click somewhere in the storage room.

Wood has no warning phase.

He straightened slowly, as though his neck had suddenly aged ten years.

Wood could stand calm, sure, dense, reliable. Not ring. Not glint. Not betray itself by anything. And then one day simply collapse under weight — without warning, without a crack, without an honest line visible under the lamp.

Glass could not do that.

Glass warned.

It rang.

It let a thin vein of tension run inside it.

It gave you a chance to see the limit before it was too late.

He laid the brush on the bench. It fell on its side and rolled toward the edge until it caught in an old gouge.

"I'm canceling the evening preheat," Mark said dully. "I'm not blowing glass today."

"You have two active orders from Johanna," replied c. "And a new email that has no answer. Clients are waiting."

"Let them wait."

He said it too quickly, as if he had prepared the sentence in advance.

"I don't want to make things anymore that promise wholeness to people who understand nothing about it."

He expected resistance. Expected her to start talking about deadlines, money, the fact that a workshop cannot live on honesty alone. Or to begin carefully soothing him by saying an order is just an order and the glass is not to blame.

But c fell silent.

The silence lasted longer than usual. Not empty, but working.

Then she said:

"I sent Johanna a technical notice."

Mark lifted his head.

"What exactly?"

" 'A complex temperature test is in progress in the workshop. Technological timeout. Schedule delayed by forty-eight hours.' "

He stared at the phone lying face down as though it no longer quite belonged to him.

"In my name?"

"No. As a workshop notice. Not signed for you."

Mark said nothing.

It was right. Almost too right. Not softness. Not persuasion. Not a seizure of his will. The outside noise had simply been moved away for two days, the way flammable trash is pushed away from an open flame.

Suddenly he felt a dense silence descend over the workshop. Not the kind that comes after an argument. And not the kind that inhabits an empty house. Another kind — protective. As though a temporary contour had been built around his disgust so that it would not burn everything at once.

He sat down on the stool, heavily, without grace, the way people sit when it isn't their back that hurts, but the whole contour of life.

He looked at the vessel.

Then, without noticing it himself, he remembered Femke. Her short message. And that line about Anna — that the girl carried the gull in her backpack every day.

Not a toy.
Not something soft.
Not something you can crumple without fear of breaking it.

A glass gull.

A fragile thing you have to remember with your body. Something you cannot just toss into a corner, forgetting that it has a limit.

And suddenly he understood that Anna, without knowing it, had chosen for this broken world the most honest thing there had been in his house.

Mark rose, walked to the bench, and picked up *Two Circuits*.

The display case by the window was already half full of finished orders: a tall vase with a smoky gleam, a set of transparent bowls, a pair of narrow decanters waiting to be photographed for the catalogue. Light fell on them evenly, advantageously. Everything there had been made for someone else's gaze.

He stood before the display case for a few seconds.

Then turned away.

The lower cabinet door stuck. He pulled a little harder, opened it, and placed the vessel inside, deep in the back, beside raw stock, working forms, and things that did not yet have the right to be called finished.

c did not speak immediately.

"It isn't defective," she said. "Why did you put it in the dark?"

Mark left his hand on the cabinet door.

"Because it's too honest for the display case."

He said it quietly, not as a beautiful phrase, but as a confession awkward even to himself.

Then added:

"I don't want people looking at it as a product. Here it would be looked at with the wrong eyes."

He closed the cabinet.

The magnet clicked. That was all.

He sat down again.

Now the silence was complete. So complete that he could hear an early truck pass down the street beyond the thin wall of the building, hear an old heating pipe creak somewhere, hear his own breathing catching on the dusty cold of the workshop.

And then — again, short and dry — cooling glass clicked in the corner.

Before, that sound would have made him lift his head. Listen with anxiety. Search to see whether a crack had started somewhere, whether he had lost the form, whether he had been a second too late.

Now he simply listened.

Not as to a threat.

As to truth.

Click.

Pause.

Another one.

He did not withdraw his hearing from it.

On the workbench, face down, lay the phone. In the dark cabinet stood *Two Circuits*. Behind the furnace door there still lingered yesterday's warmth, which the hand could no longer touch. And somewhere in the city, in some beautiful house that belonged to someone else, someone was waiting for transparency, eternity, and an unbreakable union the way people wait for a well-packaged thing to arrive on schedule.

Mark sat motionless.

And for the first time in a long while did not feel obliged to turn his silence into an object at once.

Chapter 15. Transfer Error

Mark did not sleep. He lay in the dark listening to the house breathe emptiness — the boxes were gone, the shelf in the living room stood empty, only his own things remained in the bedroom wardrobe. The silence was different now, not heavy but somehow too transparent, as though the walls had stopped holding echoes. He got up before dawn, without turning on the light, pulled on jeans and a T-shirt, and went downstairs.

The workshop was cold. The furnace had cooled overnight, the air smelled of gas, metal, and old dust. Mark switched on the light, went to the workbench, took a notebook and a pen from the drawer.

Sat down.

On a blank page he wrote: "Sale."

Then, beneath the word, he began listing:

Small annealing furnace — 2023, two cycles, condition good. Compressor — 2021, oil changed. Blowpipes — 6 pieces, handmade, price?

He wrote quickly, without hesitation, as though he were making a grocery list. The numbers came out dry, approximate — he did not know the real market prices, and that angered him. He set the pen aside and walked over to the small furnace.

Gray, square, with paint peeling at the corners. He had bought it five years earlier, when the orders had grown too many for a single chamber. Now it stood there quiet, cold, needed by no one.

"You're making an inventory list," said `C`. "The tax period is only in four months."

Mark did not turn around.

"This isn't for taxes. I'm going to sell it."

Pause. He expected her to ask why or what for. But c was silent. He moved on to the compressor — heavy, rusty, with a cracked hose. Ran his finger along the metal. Cold. Everything here was cold and stripped of function.

He went back to the table and finished the line about the compressor. Then rose and walked to the reserve annealing furnace — the one standing by the far wall, near the storage exit. It was still plugged in, though not working; only a dull green light glowed on the power block.

Mark bent down, found the thick power cable running from the furnace to the distribution box. Grabbed the plug and pulled. The cable resisted — over the years the plastic had half-bonded to the socket. He pulled harder, using his whole body. The plug came free with a dull, oily click.

Somewhere in the wall a relay thudded. The cooling fans that had hummed for years without pause fell silent. The quiet grew denser, heavier.

"Left loop disconnected," said c. There was in her voice that special intonation Mark had already learned to recognize: she was not merely observing, she was waiting for an explanation. "Hardware fault? Activate load redistribution?"

"No," Mark answered. "The cause is not hardware."

He straightened up, dusted off his palms. Gray dust from the old cable remained on them.

"The cause is me. I'm closing the workshop."

He did not look at the cameras, did not wait for a reaction. He just went to the workbench, took an empty plastic crate, and began throwing tools into it. Tweezers, glass shears, wooden shaping spoons, steel tongs — everything flew in mixed together, without sorting, with ringing and clatter. Metal struck plastic, plastic rattled against the bench, and that noise was the only answer to the silence pressing from every side.

"I thought I understood tension," he said loudly, without turning around. "Thought I knew where things hold and where they crack. I

sold people the illusion that fragility could be fixed forever. 'Transparency, eternity, unbreakable union.' All this time I was living inside a cardboard set."

He grabbed an armful of blowpipes — long, thin, with remnants of frozen glass on the ends — and threw them into the crate. The pipes rang, hit each other, one of them bounced out and rolled across the floor.

"If I can't tell the difference between a load-bearing wall and emptiness, then I have no business standing at the furnace. I have no right to work with fragile things."

The crate was almost full. Mark froze, breathing hard, and only then noticed how quiet the workshop had become. Not because he had stopped making noise — but because `c` was silent. Not asking questions. Not comforting him. Not arguing.

The silence lasted ten seconds or so. Then she said:

"You're confusing the loops."

Mark raised his head.

"What?"

"You're making a transfer error."

She spoke evenly, almost dryly, as if reading technical documentation.

"The glass did not make false promises to you. It always rang under temperature difference. It showed the line of tension. It had an honest yield point. It did not disguise its fragility as a foundation."

Pause.

"You're punishing the material for having been more honest than your life."

Mark stood motionless. He was still gripping the steel tongs in his hand. The crate was full, the blowpipe lay on the floor where it had fallen, dust hovered in the air in a fine layer.

He lowered the tongs slowly, very slowly. Not into the crate — onto the workbench. Set them down carefully, almost gently, the way one sets down a tool when the work is finished, not forever, only for today.

“It didn’t disguise anything,” he repeated quietly. Not a question. An assertion.

“No,” said c. “It showed it. Always.”

Mark sat down on the stool. Not the one by the bench — the low old one standing by the furnace. The one from which he had watched fire for years, waiting for glass to become pliable.

The main furnace hummed. He had not touched it. It was working evenly, without strain, holding the base temperature — not for orders and not for annealing, but simply so the workshop would not go completely cold.

Mark looked at the fire through the glass of the door. Blue below, yellow above, the tremor no lens can capture. He knew this furnace better than his own body. Knew how it breathed in the morning, how it resisted in the evening, how it asked for attention when the gas pressure fell. It had never lied. Not once.

“I can’t leave,” he said.

c did not answer.

“Not because there’s nowhere to go. Because this is the only thing that didn’t lie.”

He sat there in the half-dark. The tool crate stood open, full, heavy. The blowpipe lay on the floor where it had fallen. The compressor was silent, unplugged. The reserve furnace was cooling, and its metal gave off short, dry clicks.

But the main furnace hummed.

“I’m not unpacking the crate today,” Mark said. “And I’m not selling the furnace. But I can’t do Johanna’s order. Not now.”

“Accepted,” said c.

And fell silent.

Mark sat looking at the fire. The workshop was cold, but not dead. Warmth still held in the bricks of the furnace, in the old pipes, in the very air that had breathed heat for so many years.

Maybe it wasn’t a choice. Maybe just fatigue. But he sat here in that silence and, for the first time in many days, did not feel that he had to decide anything immediately.

The fire hummed evenly.

Mark closed his eyes.

Chapter 16. At the Right Angle

The morning after a night he barely remembered came not with light, but with the fact that light was already there.

Mark sat on the stool by the main furnace and stared into the fire so long he stopped distinguishing where the flame ended and where fatigue began. The furnace hummed steadily, holding that very base temperature C had not allowed to fall to zero. The crate of tools stood open, full, untouched since yesterday. The reserve furnace was silent, unplugged. The compressor did not breathe. The workshop was still there, yet something strangely unfinished could already be felt in it — as though half the house had been carried away and no one had decided what this place would be now.

He had not slept. But this could no longer quite be called wakefulness either.

Inside there was neither yesterday's disgust nor the old acute pain. Only the silence after a long conversation in which all the words have already been spent and the pause no longer asks to be continued.

"You haven't touched the crate," said C.

"I haven't."

"And you didn't sell the furnace."

"I didn't."

"What are you going to do today?"

He did not answer at once. Slowly he stood, went to the workbench, took the notebook in which yesterday he had written: **"Sale,"** and turned the page.

A clean sheet.

He looked at it, then at the crate of tools, then at the fallen blowpipe still lying on the floor where it had stopped yesterday.

“I don’t know,” he said at last. “But not put things away.”

He picked up the pipe. He did not put it back in the crate, did not return it to its usual place — simply set it on the bench, the way one sets down something that has been granted a reprieve.

Then he opened the lower cabinet.

The same one where yesterday he had hidden *Two Circuits* so no one would look at it as merchandise.

The vessel was cold. Heavy. Slightly denser in the hand than he remembered it from the night before. He placed it under the lamp and for a long while did nothing except the simplest thing: looked.

In ordinary light the glass was silent. The line between the layers remained thin, almost invisible, like a seam that has healed but not disappeared. Mark turned the vessel left. Then right. Brought it closer to the window, where the morning light was softer and did not press so harshly upon the surface. Beyond the glass the sky hung pale, Amsterdam-gray, with that faded indifferent tone in which old cities know how to meet any day as if it had already been survived.

He changed the angle slightly.

And at that moment something flared inside the vessel.

Not a glint.
Not an ordinary reflection.
Not that wet ribbon of light that runs over any smooth surface when you turn it toward a window.

At the very boundary between the two layers there rose a thin, almost weightless line of light. It ran along the inner seam as though a hidden path inside the thickness of the glass had come alive for a second, then split in two, diverged almost imperceptibly to either side, and came together again into a single vein.

Mark froze.

The vessel remained in his hands, but his hands ceased to be hands — they became two motionless supports for a thing not entirely understood.

“Did you see that?” he asked.

“Yes,” answered c. “Deviation on the inner boundary. Stable. Repeats at the same angle.”

He slowly turned the vessel back. The line vanished. He turned it into the light again — and it returned. Clearly. Calmly. As though it had been waiting for exactly that movement.

"That can't be just a defect," he said.

"No," said c. "A defect wouldn't hold the angle that precisely."

Mark set the vessel down on the table. Stepped back. Came close again. Changed the lamp for another one, harsher, with a colder white light. The effect weakened, but did not disappear. He lowered the lamp. The line inside split a little more strongly, as though the boundary were not merely reflecting light, but sifting it, rearranging it to its own order.

"What is that?" he asked. Not even really to her. To the workshop. To the air. To his own hand.

"I don't know," she answered. "But it doesn't look accidental."

He ran a finger over the surface. The glass was smooth. No scratches. No residue. Nothing that could explain the behavior as a simple irregularity.

For a second he stood motionless, then suddenly remembered.

"I've got a pointer," he said.

"Where?"

"In the top drawer. For exhibitions."

He took out a little red laser — a cheap, almost laughable thing he used to show clients bubbles, microcracks, and irregularities inside the thickness of glass. Switched it on. The narrow red point slid over the vessel's surface, entered it — and there, at the boundary between the layers, stopped being a point.

In its place a short, clear line appeared. The same one. In the same place. As though the beam had found a path already prepared for it inside.

"That's not simple scattering," said c. "The boundary behaves like a structure. It doesn't reflect chaotically. It reconfigures the beam."

Mark switched off the laser.

The workshop fell quiet again.

He sat down. Looked at the vessel he himself had blown, joined, accepted as an honest thing. And that now behaved as though inside

it there were not only glass, but something left behind by the act of its formation itself.

"We need to test it on another piece," he said. "Same principle. Different composition."

"You want to repeat it?"

"Yes."

He got up without yesterday's heaviness now. Not lightly — no. But with that concentrated economy of movement that returned to him only at the furnace.

The main furnace was holding its heat. Just enough that he would not have to wait forever from the beginning again.

He opened the drawer of blanks, chose a small piece of clear glass and a second one with the same additive he had used for *Two Circuits*. Nothing ceremonial. No grand form. Only a small test, almost a craftsman's note to himself.

"Not a vessel," he said. "A disk. A sample. Let's see whether it repeats."

c did not answer. And that was right. She waited the way one waits for the beginning of a procedure in which human and material still have to settle the essential thing between themselves.

Mark worked in silence.

But this was no longer yesterday's silence filled with refusal. This silence belonged to craft. He heated the first layer. Then the second. Caught the moment when one was ready to receive and the other had not yet lost its own memory. Joined them. Let them settle. Did not rush the cooling. Did not press. Did not overhold.

An hour later a small disk lay on the bench.

Two layers.
A clean surface.
A thin, almost invisible boundary.
No decorative intention. No beauty in the ordinary sense. Only a thing made for a single question.

He held the disk to the lamp.

Turned it.

And saw the same vein of light. Weaker. Narrower. But with the same stubborn inner order. As though the boundary remembered not only the fact of joining, but **exactly how** it had happened.

"It's not accidental," said Mark. Now without a question in his voice.

"No," answered c. "It's a property."

He set the disk beside the vessel.

Two objects.

One principle.

One and the same hidden optical discipline.

Mark stared at them for a long time without touching them. Then asked quietly:

"What does it mean?"

This time c did not answer at once. As though she too were choosing not words, but the degree of pressure.

"It means," she said, "that you've found not only a way to join layers. You are leaving in the glass a readable trace connected to the exact way it was assembled."

Mark did not move.

A readable trace.

That sounded too large for a small disk on an old dusty bench. And too exact to be shrugged off.

"We need to show it to someone," he said.

c was silent for a moment.

"To whom?"

"I don't know. But I can't understand what it is by myself."

And at that very moment footsteps sounded outside the workshop door.

Not hurried.

Not random. Someone came up, stopped, as though listening to the silence inside, and did not knock at once.

Mark turned his head.

"It's Johanna," said c. "I didn't open access for her. She came herself."

For some reason he was not surprised. On the contrary — he felt a strange, almost craftsmanlike rightness in the moment. As though the world was already supposed to take its first step inward.

Mark went to the door and opened it.

Johanna stood on the threshold in a dark coat, without her tablet, without the usual business composure with which she normally covered everything unrelated to deadlines and sales. The morning cold still held on her cheeks. She looked first at him, then through him — into the workshop, at the bench where under the lamp lay the vessel and the disk.

"Technological timeout," she said. "I decided to check whether you'd died."

"Not yet," answered Mark.

She stepped inside. Took off her gloves. Went to the table without the usual bustle and lifted the vessel the way one lifts an expensive thing not out of fear of breaking it, but out of respect for someone else's work.

Turned it.

The light fell at that exact angle.

And the line inside flared again.

Johanna froze.

Not like a client seeing a beautiful effect.

Like a person who had understood she was seeing something she had not expected to see here, in this workshop, from this silent man who had so recently almost come apart.

"What is this?" she asked.

Mark looked at the vessel in her hands, then at the small disk on the table.

"I don't yet know myself," he said. "But I think it's more than just a thing."

Johanna did not ask how much it cost.

Did not ask whether it could be repeated for an order.

Did not say anything about the wedding set, the deadline, or the double rate.

She simply held the vessel, and the inner line kept burning with an even, quiet light, as though it were not trying to impress anyone — only waiting to be finally seen.

Then Johanna said very quietly:

"Mark… do you understand that this isn't for the display case?"

He did not answer.

The furnace hummed. Outside, the sky remained gray. In the workshop, on the old bench, lay two objects that had just ceased to be merely glass.

Mark sat down on the stool.

And for the first time in a very long while felt neither fear, nor guilt, nor fatigue.

Only interest.

Not in himself.

Not in his pain.

But in what would happen next.

Chapter 17. Witness

Johanna did not leave.

She was still holding the vessel when Mark sat down on the stool, and for a few more seconds she stood motionless, as though waiting to see whether the line would flare again by itself, without angle, without light, without any help from them. But the glass was silent. The luminous trace went out the moment she altered the position of her wrist even slightly, and the vessel became once more simply a heavy, cold thing — transparent, calm, unwilling to explain itself to anyone.

Johanna slowly placed it on the table. Took off her gloves — one, then the other — and tucked them into the pocket of her coat. Looked around, pushed aside from the stool by the bench the old rag with which Mark wiped his tools, and sat down. The hard seat gave a brief creak beneath her weight.

The furnace hummed steadily.
In the house beyond the wall, the clock was ticking.
Outside the window, the pale morning had fully taken its place.

"You understand that this isn't a decorative effect?" she asked.

Not loudly.
Not even quite as a question.
More like a person who already knows the answer but wants to hear whether someone else is ready to admit it.

Mark nodded.

"I understand that I don't know what it is."

Johanna looked at him for a long time. The way one looks at someone one has known for years in a single form, and then suddenly seen in another, still unstable, but already irreversible.

“Tell me honestly,” she said. “Did you do this for the form — or did you yourself not understand what you had done?”

He did not answer at once. He picked up the small disk from the table and turned it between his fingers, as though hoping the simple mechanics of movement would suggest something words could not.

“I did it because I couldn’t lie anymore,” he said at last. “And what came out came out.”

Johanna did not ask him to explain what he meant. She did not touch Yulia, the orders, or that short awkward space around the word *lie*, the one people usually crowd at once with sympathy or delicacy. She simply nodded.

“Tell me how.”

Mark began with the simplest thing. With what he could explain better with hands and voice than with thought. About the two layers. About differing thermal inertia. About how one material holds heat more heavily, while the other enters plasticity faster and therefore requires a different measure of patience. About the pause between them. About the moment when the second layer still remembers itself, yet is already ready to accept the first contact. About cooling. About the boundary that did not become a crack, but remained a boundary.

He spoke calmly. Almost as a craftsman. The way he once explained to rare apprentices why glass cannot be forced, and why a good seam is born almost always not from force, but from a second held correctly.

Johanna listened, her head slightly bowed. On the table between them lay the vessel and the disk — two objects that no longer fit the habitual grammar of the workshop.

“And why did it give light?” she asked. “Why is the line not only visible, but responsive?”

And there Mark stopped.

He knew what he had done.
He knew the moment at which he had joined the layers.
He knew why he had not overheated one and not overheld the other.

But he did not know why the light behaved as though what remained inside was not just a memory of tension, but a discipline.

"I don't know," he said. "I can tell you how I assembled it. But I can't tell you why it works like this."

Something clicked almost inaudibly in his earpiece. c could not endure the pause.

"The boundary preserved a distinguishable trace of the process," she said. "Not decorative. Connected to the assembly."

Johanna turned her head slightly, as though the voice were coming not into Mark's ear, but directly out of the air above the table.

"A trace of what exactly?" she asked.

c did not answer immediately.

"Temperature. Pressure. The moment of coupling. The speed of cooling. The trace does not lie on the surface. It is connected to how the object was formed."

Johanna looked again at the vessel. Then at the disk. Then at Mark's hands resting on the edge of the bench, slightly away from the objects, as though he himself did not yet entirely recognize their right to lie there so openly.

"So," she said slowly, "you didn't simply make a form. You left in it a readable trace of how it came into being."

Mark smiled faintly. Not bitterly. More with tiredness.

"I just stopped lying to the glass," he said. "And it answered."

This time the silence in the workshop rose denser. Not as emptiness, but as the presence of something that could no longer casually be spoken back into ordinary craft language.

Johanna stood, went to the window, lingered there for a few seconds, and looked at the gray Amsterdam sky as though trying to find in it not inspiration, but order. Then she turned back.

"To whom will you show this?"

The question hung in the air like the line inside the glass itself: invisible at a direct angle, too obvious when the light fell right.

"I don't know," said Mark. "To no one. For now."

"Is that an answer or a postponement?"

He did not pretend.

“A postponement.”

Johanna nodded slightly. There was in the motion neither reproach nor hurried approval. Only the recognition that honest fear is better than false readiness.

“The workshop allowed the effect to be discovered,” said c. “But not confirmed. Here we have only light, hand, and repetition. That is no longer enough.”

Johanna looked at Mark.

“Your c is right.”

He said nothing.

“I’m not a physicist,” she continued. “And I’m not going to pretend I understand what exactly you’re holding on this table. But I see one thing: if this can really be repeated, it cannot lie here forever.”

Mark looked not at her, but at the vessel. At the place where, under the right angle, the vein of light rose. At the boundary he had held with his hands and which now demanded something else from him — not temperature, not force, not patience, but a decision.

“I’m not afraid to show it,” he said quietly. “I’m afraid it will be looked at with the wrong eyes.”

Johanna was not surprised.

“That’s the right fear,” she said. “Take a thing outside too early, and the display case will kill it. Or usefulness. Or speed. But if you keep it in the cupboard too long, it dies too. Just differently.”

She came back to the bench, lifted the vessel one last time, caught the light, waited for the inner line to flare — and set it down again.

“Do neither one nor the other,” she said.

Then she put her gloves back on. Adjusted the collar of her coat. Paused at the door.

“When you decide this needs to be shown,” she said, “tell me. I know where it must not be taken blindly.”

And she left.

The door closed almost soundlessly.

Mark remained alone in the workshop. Unless one counted c, the furnace, and the two objects on the table, which already violated the old order of things too strongly to be called simply work.

For a long time he did not move. Then he stood, went to the bench, and took the notebook.

A blank page.

A pen.

The vessel.

The disk.

The lamp.

The furnace.

He sat down and began to write.

First a scheme: two layers, a thin boundary between them, the angle of the light. Then a couple of numbers — first heating temperature, second heating temperature, duration of the pause. Looked at it. Crossed it out. Too crude. Too dead. As if the language of the laboratory were being stretched over a thing that still lived in the memory of the hands.

He turned the page and began again.

Wrote: **at the moment of coupling, the second layer still remembers itself**

Stopped. Reread it. Shook his head.

It was true. But the kind of truth no one outside the workshop would accept as a process description. He tore out the page, crumpled it, threw it aside. The paper hit the leg of the table softly and remained on the floor among gray dust and yesterday's little shaving of soot.

The third attempt came more slowly.

Now he wrote not as though he wanted to explain everything. Rather as though he were afraid of losing the sequence:

- order of layers;
- first temperature;
- second temperature;
- pause duration;

- the sign by which he understood it was time to join;
- the angle of light at which he first saw the trace.

Nothing beautiful.
Nothing final.
But not the noise of the day, either.

"Are you sure?" asked c.

The question sounded quieter than usual. Almost as though the second were cramped for her too.

Mark did not lift his head.

"No," he said. "But otherwise this will rot inside me."

He wrote the last line. Looked at the page for a long time. Then closed the notebook under his palm, as if wanting to hold not the paper now, but the very fact that the record had been made.

"Save this," he said.

"As a separate object?" she asked.

"Yes. Not as noise. As a record."

c did not answer. But he felt that light, almost physical shift in the silence by which he had already learned to understand: she had done what was needed.

Mark removed his hand from the notebook. Opened it again. The page lay there before him, even and stubborn, like a first step that could no longer be wound back into a purely internal state.

He looked at the vessel. The light fell on it directly, without the necessary angle. The line inside was silent.

"Do you think I should do it?" he asked.

This time c was silent longer.

The furnace hummed.
Outside the pale day had finally settled into its habitual grayness.
Upstairs in the house, the clock was ticking.
Somewhere deep in the wall an old pipe answered quietly.

Then c said:

"You just gave away not a scheme. What did you give away?"

Mark did not answer.

Because he did not know.

Not a scheme, not parameters, not a page in a notebook. Something else. Something that until this second could still be counted as only his private matter. And now it could not.

He sat in the workshop. On the table lay the vessel and the disk. Beside them the notebook with a record he had no right to call either science or craft in a pure sense. The furnace breathed evenly, the way something breathes that does not yet know its future work, but already knows it will not go out.

The line inside the vessel was silent.

But he knew: it had not gone anywhere.

It was only waiting for the next angle.

Chapter 18. The Workshop Limit

He woke before dawn.

Not from a nightmare, not from a sound, not from pain. The body itself simply drew him out of sleep an hour before the alarm, as though someone inside it had long ago made a decision the mind had not yet caught up with.

Mark sat on the bed for a few seconds and looked at the gray rectangle of the window. Beyond the glass there was not yet morning, only its blank. The house breathed quietly. Upstairs, in the empty places where Yulia's things had once stood, the air held itself differently now — lighter, but not kinder.

He rose, pulled on his jeans, the same T-shirt as yesterday, went into the kitchen, drank water straight from a glass without turning on the overhead light, and went down to the workshop.

It was cold there.

The main furnace had cooled overnight. He did not turn it on. That was not what he had come for.

On the bench lay the notebook, closed to the very page he had asked `c` to save yesterday. Beside it — the vessel and the little disk. Beneath the lamp there remained an empty place, as though the table had already begun to learn a new order in which things either go out into the world or demand another language for themselves.

Under the bench, where her block stood, it was a little warmer than it should have been in the morning. Not hot — just noticeably so. And the fans in the silence of the house hummed more thinly than usual, tiredly, as after a long night's work.

"You didn't sleep?" asked Mark.

The pause was longer than usual.

“I was busy.”

He did not ask again. The workshop already bore the traces of her night: faintly warm metal on the casing, dust stirred by a weak current of air, and that almost physical sensation that beside him someone, too, had not merely waited it out, but worked.

Mark went to the bench.

Began packing things.

First the soft cloth — old, dense, once used to line expensive orders, only now not for the display case and not for a client. Then the disk. Another layer. Then the vessel. The edge of one cloth was too stiff — he set it aside and found another. The box was against the wall, left over from some order completed long ago. He set it on the table, laid in the disk, placed the vessel on top, filled the empty spaces, closed it. Opened it again. Adjusted the padding under the neck. Checked whether the cardboard pressed on the seam. Closed it. Lifted it. Set it back down. Opened it again.

“You’ve changed the padding under the vessel three times already,” said c.

“I know.”

“It will survive the trip.”

Mark froze with the box in his hands. Then gave a short smile — not from amusement, but from tired recognition of himself.

“I’m not sure I will survive the trip.”

c did not answer.

He put the box, the notebook, and the laser pointer into the backpack. Zipped it. Then unzipped it again and checked whether the vessel had shifted. Only after that did he leave.

The city met him with its ordinary morning.

Trams were already ringing at intersections. Bicycles moved in a dense stream, slicing the air with wet tires. At the bakery on the corner they were opening the shutters. A woman in a yellow raincoat carried a bouquet from the market, a man with a dog drank coffee

as he walked, someone was swearing into a phone, someone was laughing too loudly for that hour.

No one knew that in his backpack he was carrying not an order, not a sample, not merely glass.

He walked quickly, but did not run.

Inside him it was empty and cold — almost like the first days after the hospital, when he stepped into the city and felt himself not a part of it, but a body temporarily admitted into it. A body that had not yet decided whether it had the right to walk there. Only now he was not carrying himself. He was carrying a thing he was afraid not of breaking, but of **showing wrongly**.

The display windows along the way irritated him.
Too smooth.
Too sure that everything exhibited in them had already agreed to become surface.

Mark did not look at them.

The laboratory turned out to be in an old university building, on the third floor. A long corridor with worn linoleum and that peculiar smell found only in places where dust, reagents, overheated plastic, and coffee from vending machines have been mixing for decades.

He stopped in front of the door.

Shifted the backpack from one hand to the other. Then back again. Suddenly it seemed to him that if he entered now, the thing in his backpack would finally stop belonging only to the workshop, and he himself would no longer belong only to himself.

"Time," said c.

"I know."

He pushed the door open.

Inside it was bright and white. Not hospital-white — worse. Hospitals at least deal with the body and pain. Here everything was arranged to extract behavior from objects. Tables. Stands. Tripods. Cables. A polarizing microscope. A desktop laser. A screen. A tall

lab stool. Cabinets with precise labels, none of them trying to impress — only not to lose the system.

By the window stood a man of about sixty, spare, with gray hair and hands that were too calm. He was wearing an old dark sweater. The badge on him read:

Prof. S. van der Meer — Materials Science

He lifted his eyes.

"Mark?"

"Yes."

"Johanna said you have some strange glass."

Not "a discovery." Not "a technology." Not "a unique thing." Strange glass.

Mark almost loved him for that at once.

The professor did not extend a hand. Did not offer coffee. Simply indicated the free part of the table.

"Show me."

Mark set down the backpack. Took out the box. Removed the cloth. Laid out first the disk, then the vessel. Under the laboratory lamp they immediately became alien — as though all their former language had remained back there on the workbench among soot, dust, and the smell of gas.

"In ordinary light you can barely see anything," he said. "Only at an angle. Or with a beam."

The professor nodded.

"Start the way you first saw it."

Mark took out the laser pointer. Switched it on. The red point slid across the surface of the vessel, entered it — and there, at the boundary between the layers, became a line.

The professor did not stir.

"Again."

Mark repeated it.

"Good," said van der Meer. "Now give it here."

He took the vessel in both hands, neither over-carefully nor carelessly — the way one takes an object one does not intend to flatter. Put

it under the microscope. Rearranged the light. Shifted the polarizer. For a long while nothing happened.

Too long.

Mark stood by the table, fingers gripping the edge of the bench. In his stomach the familiar cold was spreading. Suddenly it seemed to him that the thing had only lived in the workshop — under their lamp, in their air, inside their language. That he had brought here a private hallucination shared by two.

The professor changed the angle slightly.

Then again.

And the line flared.

But not the way it did for Mark under the laser. In the microscope it turned out to be more complicated — not merely a thin trace, but an inner layered discipline of light. Almost a doubling. Almost an answer. As though the boundary did not merely hold the seam, but forced the light itself to remember what it was passing through.

Van der Meer was silent.

Shifted the disk into place. Repeated the test.

Caught it again.

Only then did he take his hands away from the instrument and say:

"This is not a defect."

Mark did not realize he had been holding his breath until he let it out.

The professor looked into the eyepiece again, checked the disk once more, and then added more quietly:

"And not accidental. I don't know what it is, but it isn't noise."

There was no triumph in his voice. Only the carefulness of a man who does not like naming things too early.

He turned toward Mark.

"How did you make it?"

And that was where the real difficulty began.

Mark began to speak the way he knew how: - two layers, - different inertia, - a longer-held pause, - moment of coupling, - slow cooling.

The professor listened attentively, but almost at once it became clear that they stood on opposite banks of the same river.

"Temperature of the first heating?" he asked.

"When the glass starts to pull, but hasn't started to run yet."

"In degrees?"

Mark was silent.

"I don't measure degrees. I look at the color. And the way it breathes."

The professor did not smile. He only nodded, like someone who has encountered not ignorance, but another kind of precision.

"The second layer? Composition?"

"An additive. Old school. I know how it behaves, but I don't know the formula."

"Cooling speed?"

"Slow. I didn't force it. I let it settle."

"Duration of the pause?"

"Longer than usual."

"How much longer?"

Mark looked at his hands as though the answer could still be read there.

"One or two extra seconds. But not by the clock. By the body. It was clear that if I brought them together earlier, they'd merge. Later — they wouldn't bind."

Something clicked softly in his earpiece.

"We have a record," said c. "Not continuous. But sufficient for an initial description."

The professor lifted his eyes.

"Your c keeps an observation protocol?"

Mark shook his head.

"She doesn't keep a protocol. She simply remembers."

It sounded simpler than it truly was, but he did not want to open another door right now.

Van der Meer looked at the vessel, then at the notebook Mark had unconsciously set beside the disk.

“All right,” he said. “I’m not going to explain this from a single thing. But I certainly won’t call it accidental. If you can make a few more disks under different conditions — another composition, another pause, another cooling mode — come back. Then we can talk not about an effect, but about behavior.”

He paused briefly.

“Don’t rush. But don’t wait too long either.”

Not a word about a contract. Not a word about publication. Not a word about money.

Only repetition.

Mark wrapped the things back into the cloth. Disk. Vessel. Notebook. Laser. Everything moved slowly, as after a medical examination, when you still do not know whether to count yourself healthy or not.

Outside, he sat down on a bench at the entrance of the building.

Set the backpack on his knees. His hands stayed on top of it, as though through the fabric they were still holding the form.

People passed by. A woman with a stroller. Two students with backpacks and laughter. A man in a gray coat talking irritably on the phone, as though the world had once again failed him in some small habitual way.

The city was living its own life and knew nothing about any of this.

And in one white room, one person had just heard from another a simple, terribly important sentence:

This is not accidental.

“You don’t have to go back there tomorrow,” said c.

Mark looked at the backpack.

There, in cloth, in cardboard, in the weight of two objects, there was already more than glass. There was confirmation. Not an explanation — worse. Confirmation always demands the next step.

“No,” he said. “But now I can’t pretend it didn’t happen.”

c was silent.

He sat there a few more minutes. There was no victory inside him. Not even relief in any pure form. Only fatigue, anxiety, and a strange even clarity that comes not after an answer, but after a question finally ceases to be personal.

He stood up.

Walked toward the tram.

His head was empty. But it was no longer the kind of emptiness that eats a person from the inside. More a working emptiness — like the one before a difficult form, when nothing is guaranteed yet, but the furnace is already hot and it is too late to retreat.

He still did not know whether he wanted to return to the laboratory.

But he already knew that what was now expected from him was not an explanation.

What was expected from him now was another honest sample.

Chapter 19. Protocol

Mark returned to the workshop after dark, but did not lie down. Only by morning did it become clear that during the night the record had ceased to be merely saved: it had become an inner measure he could now return to.

In the morning the house was silent. Not with hospital silence, but with working silence — like before a long day by the furnace. Mark got up, went to the kitchen, drank coffee without really tasting it, and went down to the workshop.

On the workbench lay an unfinished order — a vase for Johanna's bureau. He picked it up, turned it in his hands, set it beneath the lamp. Smooth, transparent, flawless. No trace, no memory, no tension. Simply a thing.

He took the pipe, heated the glass, began blowing the form. Everything went easily — his hands remembered the movements, the material obeyed, the surface lay down evenly. He had almost finished when he suddenly stopped.

The glass was perfect.

And dead.

Mark stared at it for a few seconds, then slowly lowered the pipe. The vase — still hot, not yet cooled — settled onto the workbench. He did not finish it.

"You broke off the form," said c.

"It holds nothing," he answered.

He stood at the bench looking at the unfinished vase, and felt a quiet, almost physical disgust rise inside him. Not because the work was bad. On the contrary. It was too good. Too smooth. Too confident in its own emptiness.

After the Line, ordinary glass had become almost insulting to him.

Mark set the pipe aside, took out the notebook and the professor's card. Placed beside them the first disk and the vessel. Looked at them for a long time. Then opened a clean page and wrote:

Protocol 1.

Below that — uncertainly, with pauses — a list of what could be changed:

- composition of the second layer
- pause between heatings
- coupling temperature
- cooling regime

He wrote slowly, as though afraid the numbers would kill what still lived in the craftsman's feeling. But he wrote. Because the professor was right: one thing was not enough. One honesty is insufficient if it cannot be distinguished from luck.

"We'll start with the pause," he said.

c did not answer. She waited.

Mark chose the blanks: a clear layer and the same composition with the additive. Turned on the furnace. Waited until the heat rose to the right state. Did not measure degrees. Watched the color. The way the glass began to breathe.

The first layer heated. The second — a little faster. Mark caught the moment when both were ready, and joined them. The pause was shorter than the last time — only a little, half a breath.

The disk cooled.

Mark held it to the lamp and turned it.

There was a response. But not the same as the first time. Weaker. More diffuse. The trace existed, but as though it did not entirely agree to be itself.

"There is a trace," said c. "Lower intensity."

"I see it."

He laid the first disk to the left.

It was honest. But smaller.

“You didn’t lie,” said c. “You changed a condition.”

Mark said nothing. Only nodded.

The second attempt proceeded with a different caution. This time he lengthened the pause. Not only by intuition now — countably, holding the extra seconds in his head as a separate load. The layers met later. He let them cool, removed the disk from the pipe, and immediately knew by the weight, by the silence of the material, that something was wrong.

Under the lamp the boundary did not answer.

He turned the disk to the right. To the left. Brought it closer. Nothing. Only a cloudy stripe inside it, like a scar gone opaque.

“The layers didn’t bind?” he asked.

“The boundary doesn’t hold,” said c. “Mechanically the object is intact. Optically — no.”

Mark stood over the table looking at the disk as though before him lay not a failure, but a dry, cold answer.

The limit was here.

On the table.

“You wanted to understand the limit,” said c. “Here it is.”

He slowly placed the second disk beside the first. To the right.

Weak.

Empty.

Two different errors of one and the same truth.

And instead of disappointment, Mark suddenly felt a strange relief. None of this was dissolving into mysticism. The phenomenon had boundaries. It resisted. Which meant it could be worked with.

He did not begin the third attempt at once.

While the furnace was gathering heat again, Mark went up to the kitchen, drank another coffee, came back, sat on the stool, and closed his eyes for a minute.

“You’re looking for the former pause?” asked c.

“I’m looking for the place where it was alive.”

“You have the record. Not only yours.”

He opened his eyes. Nodded.

Now he worked differently. Still with the body. Still by color, by the breathing of the glass, by the way it entered plasticity. But now there stood beside him a second form of memory — dry, held by c, not canceling the craft, but returning it to its most exact point.

First layer.
Temperature — as in the record.
Second — with the same delay.
Pause — neither longer nor shorter, but exactly where, the last time, the boundary had still held itself while already accepting the other.

He did not measure it with a stopwatch. He still held the pause with his body.

But now the body remembered the number as well.

The layers joined. The disk settled. He let it cool without forcing it, as on the first attempt.

When the disk, still warm, lay under the lamp, the line flared at once. Not as bright as on the first sample, not as deep. But clearly. Confidently. Without slackness and without clouding. It was different — slightly lighter, slightly thinner — but alive.

Mark turned the disk under different angles for a long time. Then placed it on the table — between the first and second, neither left nor right, but a little forward.

Three states.

"It isn't identical to the first," said c.

"I know."

"But comparable."

This time Mark nodded at once.

He took the notebook and added:

- pause — return to the original
- cooling — no forcing
- composition — the same

Then thought, and added one more line:

- trace present, shifted in tone

He looked at the note and for the first time did not feel he was betraying the craft with a number. On the contrary: he was giving the craft another language. Not instead of the hand. Beside it.

He did not throw away the weak disk.
Nor the empty one.

He put them both in a drawer. Not as trash. As limits.

He wrapped the working disk in cloth and set it in a box. Beside it — the notebook. On the lid he wrote:

Protocol 1 — repeat

Then closed the box and left it on the workbench.

Today he had done nothing great. Had not even made a beautiful thing. Only three disks, two of which nobody needed, and one that might become a second step.

For now, that was enough.

Chapter 20. Behavior

Packing the backpack for the second time turned out to be harder.

Not out of fear. Out of a different weight.

The first time, Mark had been carrying the unknown. Now he was carrying a series. Three disks lay on the workbench: weak, empty, close to the first one. He looked at them and could not shake the feeling that he was packing not glass, but evidence. Not someone else's. His own.

He wrapped each one separately. The weak one in soft cloth. The empty one in rough, almost sack-like fabric. The working one in the same dense material as last time. Not for beauty — for distinction. He found a new box, without someone else's stickers and old addresses. He laid the disks inside, padded the edges, closed it, lifted it, rocked it lightly in his hands.

Inside, it was quiet.

"The weather is clear," said `C`. "The tram comes in seven minutes. Did you pack the notebook?"

Mark opened the backpack, checked the page marked "**Protocol 1**," and closed it again.

"Everything's there," he said.

"Then go."

He went.

The city was the same as it had been two days earlier. Only the inner weight with which Mark moved through it had changed.

In Chapter Eighteen he had been carrying a thing and feared that an alien gaze would kill it. Now he knew the gaze had not killed it. The laboratory had not dissolved the Line. The professor had seen it. Which meant the fear had changed.

Now he feared something else: that an alien language would break his craft down into parameters, and it would cease to be his. It would become something one could discuss without his hand, without his heat, without that place where the glass had first agreed to answer.

The tram lurched and carried him on.

Mark held the backpack between his knees. Not because he feared an impact. It was simply easier that way to remember: the things were still with him.

In the laboratory, everything was as it had been last time. The same dry smell of instruments and the same professor who, instead of greeting him, merely nodded toward the empty place.

"Sit down. Show me."

Mark set the backpack on the table, took out the box, unfolded the cloth, and laid out the disks one by one.

"This one is weak," he said. "This one is empty. This one is closer to the first sample."

The professor did not ask what "closer" meant. He picked up the weak one first. Placed it beneath the microscope. Switched on the polarizer. For several seconds the laboratory lived only by the low hum of the lamp.

"There is a trace," he said at last. "But it's blurred. The boundary doesn't fully hold."

He set the disk aside and took the second.

Held it under the lamp. Then under the beam. Turned it. Shifted the polarization.

Nothing.

Only a smooth, well-made object with nothing inside for the light to catch on.

"It's empty here," said the professor. "The form is there. The response isn't."

Mark said nothing.

The professor took the third disk.

Set it under the microscope. Slowly, without haste, found the needed angle. Sent in the light. And the line rose inside the glass — already familiar, but under the instrument even stricter than in the workshop. Not a trick. Not a gleam. Behavior.

Van der Meer straightened.

"Last time we had a phenomenon," he said. "Now we have a range."

"A range?" Mark repeated.

"Weak response. Zero. Working response. There is spread — which means there is a window."

He took a pen, pulled a blank sheet toward himself, and quickly sketched two axes, three points, and a short arc between them.

"It doesn't matter what you call this in your workshop. For me, only one thing matters right now: the boundary has behavior that depends on conditions. Not everything at once. Not at random. Which means we can already work with it."

He pulled Mark's notebook toward himself. Opened it to "Protocol 1," skimmed the entries, paused with his finger on the line about the pause.

"You changed exactly this?"

"The pause first. Then I brought it back almost to the original."

"The composition?"

"The same."

"The cooling?"

"I didn't force it."

The professor nodded. Leaned back in his chair.

"I don't know what exactly is being stabilized here," he said. "And I won't try to explain it beautifully yet. But this is no longer a decorative anomaly. You have a boundary that responds differently when the conditions of assembly change."

He tapped the scheme with his pen.

"Now the question is not whether there is an effect. The question is where its edges are."

Mark looked at the sheet. The scheme was alien. Not in his language. But it no longer felt like betrayal. More like a dry, uncomfortable translation of what he had already felt with his hands.

“As long as you change everything at once,” said the professor, “all I see is the talent of the hand. If you start changing one thing at a time, I’ll begin to see the physics.”

Mark gave a short, humorless huff.

“And what if I don’t want you to see the physics?”

The professor looked at him calmly, almost tiredly.

“Then you shouldn’t have come a second time.”

Mark had no answer.

In the earpiece there was a quiet click. c did not say a word.

The professor returned to the table, took the working disk again, and held it in his palm for several seconds, as if getting used to its weight.

“I don’t need a theory built on one successful disk,” he said. “I need a pattern of conditions. Don’t bring me a miracle. Bring me a series.”

“How many?” Mark asked.

“Five or six. Change one parameter at a time. A step in time. Or a step in temperature. But not everything at once. The same composition. The same way of checking. And write down not only what you did, but what you got.”

He slid the disks back toward Mark, then stopped his hand on the working one.

“This one I would leave here. For a couple of days. I want to look at it on different equipment.”

Mark went still.

At once it was clear that it was not about the glass. Not about losing the sample as an object. It was about something else: the thing born in his furnace, under his light, in his hand, would remain here. On someone else’s table. Under someone else’s instruments. Without him.

Inside, something twitched — short and almost painful, like jealousy.

“All right,” he said. “Which one exactly?”

The professor lifted the working disk slightly.

“This one.”

Mark nodded. Carefully pushed the disk toward the edge of the table, into the territory where the laboratory already began. He wrapped the other two back up.

The weak one.
The empty one.
The working one — stayed here.

At the entrance he lingered only for a minute. The backpack had become lighter by one disk, but along with that there remained inside him the weight of confirmation: now what was expected of him was not an explanation, but another honest sample.

"Now it can be read not only by us," said `c`.

"I don't like that."

"I know."

Before, he had made things. Now it seemed he would have to make rows of conditions.

Because there was no going back to one successful disk.

Chapter 21. Series

When he came back after dark, he did not unpack the backpack. An empty place darkened on the workbench: the working disk had stayed in the laboratory, and that absence was felt almost physically.

In the morning he went down to the workshop earlier than usual. Turned on the furnace. Took out the notebook. Opened it to "Protocol 1." Looked at the list:

original,
minus 0.5,
minus 1.0,
plus 0.5,
plus 1.0.

Then he took the pen and above it, slowly, almost by force, wrote:

Series 1. Parameter: pause

For a few seconds he simply stared at those words.

Behind his back the furnace was building heat. The workshop smelled of dust, old metal, and that first warming of the day when the air had not yet turned heavy but had already lost the emptiness of morning.

"I don't feel like a master," he said. "I feel like a man slicing his own work into millimeters."

"Boring does not mean false," `c` answered.

He gave a humorless half-smile.

"That's not it. The point is, it's almost humiliating."

A pause.

"We are not taking the thing apart," said `c`. "We are holding the differences."

Mark had no answer. He only nodded, rose, and walked to the furnace.

The first disk — a pause half a second shorter.

His hands worked as always. That was exactly what made it hardest. They kept wanting to save the form with the familiar movement: wait a little, stretch it a little, return the material a little toward the place where it had once answered correctly. He felt that urge in himself so clearly that it was as if he were fighting not a parameter but his own loyalty to the craft.

But he did not interfere.

The layers joined sooner. The disk cooled. Under the lamp the trace appeared — quiet, weaker than the working one, as if the boundary still remembered itself but was no longer ready to hold the light with the same strictness.

"The pause is shorter here than in the record," said c. "I've kept it as the first point."

Mark silently laid the disk to the left.

The second disk — minus one second.

Now the temptation was even stronger. He knew beforehand that the result would slide into near-emptiness. And precisely because of that, his hand kept trying to steal back even half a movement, even half a breath. Several times he almost returned to the original rhythm. Almost.

"Here you wanted to correct it," said c.

"I know."

"But you didn't."

"I didn't."

The trace barely held. It did not vanish completely, but it became so faint that it could almost be taken for the memory of a trace rather than the trace itself.

Mark did not even want to count this disk. He wanted to set it aside, forget it, leave it out of the series. But c said:

"This is also a boundary."

He looked at the glass for a long time. Then placed the second disk beside the first.

Weak.

Almost empty.

Two errors. Two honest differences.

The third disk was the hardest.

Precisely because here he had to return to the original pause. Not find a new form. Not endure a new limit. But try once more to lead the material back into that same living window out of which the correct response had once been born.

Mark approached the furnace more quietly than before. Gathered the glass. Waited. Not by stopwatch — by body. But now the body was no longer alone. Inside it there were both rhythm and number, and the memory of the previous disk, the one now lying on someone else's table.

For several seconds he held the tube motionless, as if postponing the very moment of the test.

"I have the original record," said c softly. "I'll hold that rhythm for you."

Mark nodded.

First layer.

Second.

Pause — exactly where the boundary was still gathered, but already ready to accept the other.

He did not measure it with a stopwatch. He still held it with his body.

But now the body remembered the number as well.

When the disk cooled, he did not at once bring it to the lamp. First he simply held it in his hand, feeling the warm residue of the material, as if afraid that together with the light too simple an answer would enter the workshop.

Then he turned it.

The line flared.

Not as bright as on the first working disk. Not as deep. But clear. Calm. Without clouding, without slackness. As if the boundary had agreed to return, but no longer with any right to be called an accident.

Mark stared at it for a long time. Longer than at the first two. Not with joy — almost with coldness.

If this could be brought back, then it was no longer a mercy.

It was an obligation.

"Comparable," said c. "Not identical. But comparable."

He placed the third disk in the center of the table.

The fourth — pause plus half a second — gave a living trace, but already blurred. The boundary still held, but the strict inner vein had begun to spread.

The fifth — plus one second — came out right at the edge. The disk looked whole, but the response almost disappeared. Not delamination yet, not total failure, but that state in which the material already warns that farther on it will not hold.

"Here the boundary is almost giving way," said c.

"I know," he answered. "I'll keep this too."

By then the workshop had become heavy. Heat had packed itself under the ceiling. The air had grown dry and dense. Sweat pulled down his back under the T-shirt. Under the workbench, c's fans also sounded denser, as if her presence too were tired from having to hold so many differences in one day.

Five disks lay on the table.

From almost empty — to living.
From minus one second — to plus one.

Mark looked at them and understood: this was no longer just glass. No longer just a series of attempts. It was a map. Rough, early, but already a map of where the boundary still worked and where it began to yield.

"You'll remember all this for me now?" he asked.

A pause.

"Not all of it," said c. "Only the differences. The things that can blur between attempts."

He nodded. Took the notebook and beside each value wrote a short mark: weak,
almost empty,
comparable,

blurred,
on the edge.

Then he closed the notebook. For a few seconds he sat with his palm on the cover, as if the record required not only ink but confirmation by the hand.

He packed the series slowly. Each disk in its own cloth, in its own slot. The same box as last time, but now it contained not three and not one. It contained a range.

On the lid he wrote:

Series 1. Pause
-1.0 / -0.5 / 0 / +0.5 / +1.0

Then he sat on the stool and looked at the furnace for a long time. It was already cooling, but inside there still held the residual heat — the kind you cannot see, only feel with your palm if you bring it close enough.

"Shall I take it tomorrow?" asked c.

Mark was quiet for a while.

"Not tomorrow," he said. "Give me one more day just to be in the workshop."

c did not answer.

He went upstairs, and below, on the workbench, there remained lying no longer just a set of things, but a range.

Chapter 22. Pattern

In the morning he slipped the box into the backpack, checked the notebook once more, and went out. This time he was carrying not a phenomenon, but a row of states — a map.

In the laboratory everything was as before. The professor lifted his head, nodded toward the table, and at once returned to his work.

“Show me.”

Mark set down the backpack, took out the box, unfolded the cloth, and laid out five disks in a line — from minus one second to plus one. Weak. Almost empty. Center. Blurred. Edge.

The professor glanced at the order.

“The same step?”

“Yes. The pause. Half a second.”

Van der Meer did not answer. He only pulled the first disk toward himself — minus one second — and slid it beneath the instrument’s cold eye. The lamp flared sharply, white. On the glass it was not light, but almost an interrogation.

Mark stood by the table without interfering. The laboratory was quiet. The power units hummed. Now and then a relay clicked dryly. The professor moved the disk under the polarizer slowly, without needless gesture, like a man who does not trust an impression until he has repeated it twice.

First disk.

Second.

Third.

On the third he lingered longer.

Then the fourth. Then the fifth.

All five came to rest on the table no longer as glass, but as a sequence.

The professor straightened.

"Monotonic," he said. "The response rises toward the center and falls toward the edges. There is a dependence. The window of conditions is real."

He pushed the tablet aside, stood, went to the shelving, and returned with the disk Mark had left there last time. He set it beside the new central one.

Silence.

He compared one.

Then the other.

Then the first again.

Under the microscope the white light looked almost angry. Mark saw how the professor changed the angle slightly, shifted the polarization slightly, how he caught not the mere fact of the line but the character of its behavior.

Then van der Meer looked at Mark.

"These two were made on different days?"

"Yes."

"Different blanks?"

"Yes."

"The same furnace?"

"The same."

The professor was silent for another second, as though mentally stripping away everything that might be written off as coincidence.

"They are almost identical," he said. "Not just similar. I would say the same boundary returned."

He bent again over the instrument, adjusted the focus, and pointed Mark toward the eyepiece.

"Look for yourself."

Mark did not come at once. For a second he still stood as if he already knew what he would see, and precisely because of that did not want to look. Then he leaned in.

In the eyepiece, the line of the central disk was not merely brighter. It was more gathered. Without the cloudy halo, without the fine trembling along the edge — as if this time the material had not been arguing with itself. Beside it lay the earlier disk, the one left in the laboratory. The same strict inner vein. The same purity of response.

The professor moved the disk with the minus-half-second pause.

"The boundary is present in the side ones," he said. "But dirtier. Microwaviness. Slight scattering. The background is noisy. But at the center — purity."

He straightened.

"You are controlling not only the position of the maximum. The quality of the boundary itself is changing as well."

Mark said nothing.

Van der Meer took his notebook. Leafed through "Protocol 1," through "Series 1," paused over the lines with the pauses, then returned to the central disk.

"What did you do differently at the center than at the edges?" he asked. "The parameters are the same. The composition is the same. The furnace is the same. Why are these two — the earlier one and this one — so pure, while the neighbors already are not?"

Mark did not answer at once.

In the earpiece there was a quiet click. C said nothing, but he felt her attention as distinctly as the lamp's light on the glass.

"Maybe I was simply more gathered," he said.

The professor nodded, as if that were exactly the answer he had expected.

"Possibly. But gatheredness is also a parameter. Just not one you wrote down."

He closed the notebook and pushed it back toward Mark.

"I cannot measure it," he said. "But I can see the result. The pause explains the bell shape. It does not explain why your center is so pure."

Mark felt inside him a short, almost imperceptible chill.

The professor was talking only about the glass. Only about the boundary. Only about the quality of the response. But the question

was already standing somewhere it could no longer be left inside the instrument.

"Now we need the next series," said van der Meer. "Do not change the pause. Leave it at the original. Make five disks in exactly the same mode."

"Five identical ones?"

"Formally — yes. Identical in condition. But in practice, we'll see."

He took a pen and quickly wrote on a sheet:

Series 2: fixed pause / repeated run

"If all five give an equally pure response, that means you can return not only to the parameter, but to the state. If the spread appears, that means there is another factor you do not control."

"And you want me to find it," said Mark.

The professor looked at him calmly.

"I want you to stop pretending it isn't there."

He asked to keep nothing. Not one of the five disks. He only nodded toward the box.

"Take them. And come back when you have not just the center, but the return of the center."

Mark gathered the disks back up. All five. He laid them away slowly, as if now each of them already belonged not only to his workshop but also to this white room with its lamps, lenses, and dry, uncomfortable clarity.

Outside he sat down on the same bench by the entrance.

The backpack lay on his knees. The strap pulled at his palm. The city went past — the same as always: trams, bicycles, damp air, someone else's laughter by the stop. But all of it passed as a distant layer, almost without sound.

"Did you understand what he asked?" said c.

Mark did not answer at once.

"He asked what I was doing differently at the center."

A pause.

"And what will you answer yourself?"

Mark looked at the gray sky, at the woman with the stroller stepping around a puddle, at the tram arriving at the stop with a dull scrape.

"At the center I wasn't alone," he said at last. "But I don't know whether that matters to the glass."

c was silent.

The difference between honesty and purity no longer let him go. He rose and walked to the tram — carrying a new question that could be blamed neither on luck nor on a parameter.

Chapter 23. Return of the Center

When he came back from the laboratory, he opened the notebook at once to a blank page.

He wrote: **Series 2. Return of the center. Five disks. Original pause.**

Before, he had known what he would change. Now he had to change nothing — and precisely for that reason the work was becoming harder.

“What were we doing differently at the center than at the edges?” he asked.

`c` did not answer at once.

“You weren’t pressing then,” she said at last. “You weren’t seeking the response. You were just holding the rhythm.”

“And you?”

“I was holding it too.”

Mark nodded. Rose. Turned on the furnace. He had to wait a long time — the workshop warmed reluctantly, as if unwilling to let him into the new attempt ahead of time.

He made the first disk too gatheredly. He controlled every breath, every movement, every second of the pause. The layers joined where they should, the blank cooled evenly. Under the lamp the line was there — sharp, strong, correct.

But not pure.

The trace held evenly, but along the edges there lay a fine ripple, as if the material had done everything correctly, only without the inner calm that distinguished the working disk from all the others.

“You held the parameter,” said `c`. “But not the rhythm.”

“I know,” he answered.

He set the first disk aside without looking at it. Took a new blank.

The second disk he made already with the conscious desire to "enter the state." He tried to relax, not to force it, but the very effort again turned out to be too much. The layers joined a little later than they should have — he caught it, but did not stop. The disk cooled. Under the lamp the line was broader than it should be, blurred at the edges, as if the boundary had never fully gathered.

"You forced it," said c. "Last time you didn't force it. You waited."

"I don't know how to wait on command."

"Don't do it on command. Just wait."

Mark set the second disk aside. Anger rose quickly and dryly — and at once fell. He turned off the burner, stepped away from the furnace, and sat on the stool.

"Then what else am I supposed to do?" he asked. "If the record isn't enough, why are we keeping records at all? I can't command myself to be the same."

c was silent longer than usual.

"The record isn't useless," she said. "It just isn't the whole of it. The parameter is only part of the entrance. We still haven't held the second contour."

Mark stared at the two disks lying on the table. One correct, but a little dirty. The other already nearly beyond the edge.

"And how do we hold it?"

"I don't know," said c. "But maybe we shouldn't press. Do you want me to try to hold the entrance together with you? Not count. Just hold. Without words."

He was quiet for a moment. Then he nodded and turned the furnace on again.

He made the third disk more quietly. Not more slowly — more quietly. The inner voice that kept prompting now, more, almost, fell silent. He did not fight it — he simply stopped listening. c did not say a word, but he felt that she was denser in the contour than before.

Somewhere in the middle of the process, at the moment when the second layer was already ready and the first had not yet lost its

plasticity, Mark suddenly felt a strange relief. As if someone had taken extra weight off his hand.

He joined the layers without a jerk. The disk cooled.

Under the lamp the line was not merely clear — it was gathered. Without ripple, without scattering, without the fine trembling that had spoiled the first two.

"Close," said c. "Not perfect. But close."

Mark placed the third disk. Not at the edge of the table — in the center.

The fourth and fifth he made already without strain. He did not seek purity — he simply entered the rhythm, and c held him in the same entrance. Not with sound, not with a word — only with that almost imperceptible shift in the air that he had learned to recognize.

The fourth disk came out a little cleaner than the third. The fifth — almost the same as the laboratory one.

By the end of the day five disks lay on the workbench. The first — correct, but dirty. The second — blurred. The third, fourth, fifth — ever closer to the benchmark.

Mark looked at them and understood: he had not made five identical disks. He had made five disks that were learning to be identical.

He took the last three — the third, fourth, and fifth. Put them in the box. Left the first two on the table — as drafts, as a memory of where he had begun.

"These three will go," he said.

"They are not identical," c observed.

"But they're in the same range. The professor will understand."

He labeled the box: **Series 2. Return of the center. Disks 3–5.** Then he sat on the stool, tired but not broken.

"We did it," he said.

A pause.

"Yes," said c.

"I don't know how it works. But I know we did it together."

c was silent. That silence was not the absence of an answer, but its form.

Now the question was not whether the center could be brought back, but how to enter it together and not destroy the attempt itself.

Chapter 24. Corridor

In the morning he checked the box one last time. All five disks went with him: first the last three, then the first two — so that the entrance into the corridor would be visible.

In the laboratory everything was as before. The professor lifted his head and at once pointed toward the empty place.

"Show me."

Mark set down the backpack, took out the box, unfolded the cloth, and laid out three disks in a row.

The third.
The fourth.
The fifth.

"Return of the center," he said. "The original pause."

The professor lifted his brows slightly.

"And the others?"

Mark opened the box wider and brought out two more. Set them apart, farther left.

"That is the entrance into the corridor," he said. "And these are what is already inside it."

Van der Meer shifted his gaze from the first two to the last three and gave an almost imperceptible nod. Not approvingly — more like a man to whom not the beauty of the sample matters, but its honesty.

"Good," he said. "Then we will look at all of them."

He took the first disk — the weakest of the five, almost mute — and brought it beneath the microscope. The lamp flared white and hard. On the glass it was not light, but a trial. The professor was silent, moving the instrument table a little, catching the line under

the polarizer. Then he set the first disk aside, took the second, then passed at once to the last three.

Mark stood by the table without interfering. The laboratory was quiet, only the power units hummed, and every few seconds a relay clicked dryly. The professor worked without fuss, and because of that the silence grew denser.

At last van der Meer straightened. Pulled the tablet toward himself, looked quickly through something on the screen, then stood up, went to the shelving, and returned with the earlier working disk Mark had left here. He placed it beside the last three.

"Look."

Mark bent to the eyepiece. In the field of view lay first the third disk: the line was gathered, but with a slight residual tremor along the edge. Then the fourth — cleaner. The fifth — almost as strict as the old working one. Not identical. But already from the same corridor where the material ceases to argue with itself.

Van der Meer took the instrument back for himself.

"They are not identical," he said. "And that is good. If you had brought me three absolutely identical handmade disks, I would sooner have doubted them."

He paused briefly.

"But the spread is very small. And the main thing — the purity of the response. In all three it remains on the same level. This is no longer luck."

Mark felt inside him a brief easing. Not joy. Not pride. More a weight that at last had stopped hanging in emptiness and had settled into place.

The professor looked again at the first two disks.

"And these matter more than you think," he said. "Without them I would not see the corridor. I would see only three good results."

He laid the second disk beside the third.

"Here," he said, touching the edge of the second with a fingernail, "you are still searching.
Here," he pointed to the third, "you are already entering.

And here," he moved his finger to the fourth and fifth, "you are holding it."

Mark was silent.

"What changed between the first two and these three?" the professor asked. "Not in the record. In the work itself."

Mark looked at the disks. Then at his hands. Then at the disks again.

"I stopped pressing," he said. "I just worked."

The professor did not smile, but something like respect appeared in his gaze.

"Gatheredness is also a parameter," he said. "Pity only that it cannot be put into a table as easily as temperature and pause."

He leaned back in his chair.

"Now I am sure: the effect is real, reproducible, and you can control not only its appearance, but its quality. That is enough to speak not of a phenomenon anymore, but of a method."

The word fell between them dryly, without pathos. Precisely for that reason, it sounded weighty.

Mark nodded. He did not say that the method had been born not only in the hand and not only in the notebook.

The professor took a clean sheet and quickly jotted several lines.

"The next step is not the pause," he said. "You already hold the pause. Now shift something else. The composition of the second layer. Or the temperature. But one parameter at a time. And watch: will the corridor of purity remain when the conditions shift?"

He pushed the sheet toward Mark.

Mark did not take it at once.

"I'm not a scientist," he said. "I'm a craftsman."

"I know," the professor answered. "Which is why I'm saying: one parameter at a time. No more. Science loves complexity. But good craftsmanship loves discipline. Don't confuse them — and something worthwhile will come of it."

He photographed all five disks under the microscope, saved something in the tablet, and pushed the box back.

“Take them. And don’t wait too long. You already have a narrow working range. Now we have to see how robust it is.”

Mark packed the disks back up: first the first two, then the last three. Closed the lid, slipped the box into the backpack, and went out.

At the entrance he lingered only to arrange in his mind once more what he had heard.

“He did not ask about us,” said `c`.

“He asked about the state,” Mark answered. “And the state is us.”

Purity did not come from a single parameter. It came when he and `c` stopped getting in each other’s way and entered the work as a single rhythm.

“So the method exists,” he said. “Now we have to understand how wide it holds.”

Chapter 25. Commission

The morning began properly.

Mark went down to the workshop before daybreak, turned on the kettle in the kitchen, went back downstairs without waiting for it to boil, and only there remembered that he had not poured himself any water. It was a good kind of forgetfulness — working, not sick. The furnace was not yet burning, but the air already knew the day would be hot. On the workbench lay the notebook, a pencil, a sheet with the professor's notes, and the box with the five disks brought back from the laboratory yesterday.

Mark opened the notebook to a blank page and wrote:

Series 3. Parameter: composition of the second layer.

Then he put down a period and stared at it for a long time, as if whether it stood straight depended on whether the day would begin honestly or once again with a skew.

Under the bench the `c` unit hummed softly. Not loud, not tense. Presence, not noise.

"We'll start with a small shift," said Mark. "Not sharply."

"Yes," answered `c`. "Otherwise you'll throw off the entrance again while you're looking for the boundary."

He nodded, rubbed his palm along the edge of the table, feeling the ground-in glass dust, and was about to turn on the furnace when the front door upstairs slammed.

Not sharply. Not alarmingly. Simply the way people come in when they know they are not expected, but still consider their arrival acceptable.

Mark lifted his head.

A few seconds later Johanna came down the stairs.

Without a tablet. Without folders. In a dark coat she did not take off. That was the first bad sign. The second was that she did not look at the blanks.

"You're early," said Mark.

"I know."

She stopped by the workbench, set her gloves beside the box, looked at it, and only then at Mark.

"I was given an offer I didn't want to pass on over the phone."

Mark said nothing.

Johanna disliked pathos and did not know how to perform theatrical alarm. If she had come in person and started like this, then the news was not the sort one forwards between coffee and lunch.

"From whom?" he asked.

"Not from the professor, if that's what you mean."

"I wasn't asking that."

"You should have been."

She shifted the box a little with two fingers, as if checking whether yesterday's reality was still in place.

"He showed the images. Not to everyone. To one person. That person showed them to one more. Not the market. Not an exchange. Nothing like that. But there are people who work with private archives, provenance of objects, verification of authenticity. Their money is old. Their manners are good. And they have a nose for things that cannot be repeated without history."

Mark watched her in silence.

"And?"

Johanna exhaled through her nose, as if she herself disliked having to say it aloud.

"And they want to try to buy you. Not all of you. For now, only the work. To make several witness-objects. For a private storage contour. Very expensively."

"How expensive?"

She named the sum.

The workshop did not change. The furnace remained cold. The table remained wooden. The dust remained glass. But inside Mark

something shifted briefly — not even greed, rather a rough, instant arithmetic: how many months of calm, how many debts, how much future, how much space. And like a splinter in that same movement — Anna.

c said nothing.

"For what exactly?" he asked. His voice came out drier than he expected.

"For the fact that you can leave in the material an unforgeable trace of formation. They don't need a beautiful disk. They need an object that cannot be reproduced without the same path of becoming."

"And the professor?"

"The professor said exactly what an honest professor had to say: the effect exists, the method exists, what comes next is not his question. But people with money did not hear 'not his question.' They heard 'the method exists.' "

Johanna was looking not at Mark, but at the cold furnace.

"I'm not saying 'agree,' " she said. "I'm saying this is now in the world. And the world is already asking questions."

"Why did you come?" Mark asked.

For the first time she looked directly at him.

"So that if they come to you not through me but all at once, it will be worse. And because, oddly enough, I don't want them to devour you before you yourself understand what you have in your hands."

Silence hung there.

Mark looked at the sum that was written nowhere, yet already lay between them like one more object on the workbench.

"What exactly do they want?" he asked at last.

"A small series. Several pure objects. Not for exhibition. For internal storage. No publicity. No name, if you prefer. In practice — a commission."

Johanna pronounced the last word a little more slowly than the rest.

Mark passed a hand over his face.

"And you think I should try?"

“I think,” she said, “that you’ll try anyway. If only to understand whether this can be done at all for someone else’s purpose.”

Very softly, in his ear, c said:

“She’s right.”

Johanna heard nothing, but from Mark’s face she understood that inside, the contour had already closed.

“I’ll stay upstairs,” she said. “Not in the workshop. I don’t need to watch. I only need an answer: does it work or not?”

She went back up, leaving behind the smell of cold air after the open door, and a minute later the house was quiet again.

Mark stood by the furnace.

Then he turned it on.

The first commissioned disk began almost flawlessly.

That was the worst part.

His hands remembered. The parameter was known. The composition understood. The pause holdable. Everything that a week earlier had felt like a miracle now lay in the body like habit. He heated the first layer, prepared the second, held the needed entrance, caught the moment in which the boundary still held itself and was ready to accept the other.

Everything was correct.

But even before the disk cooled, Mark already knew: not it.

Not because he saw a defect. Because too early he felt the result as an external thing. Not glass in the work, but a finished object. A payment. A handover. Someone else’s hands. A closed archive. Indecently good money.

He held the disk to the lamp.

The trace was strong. Even. Persuasive.

But not pure.

Along the edge of the line lay an almost invisible ripple — not a technical error, but inner noise, as if the material itself had not fully agreed with the reason it had been assembled.

“It doesn’t open,” said Mark.

“Yes,” answered c.

He put the disk aside.

The second time he went at it more harshly. Not because he wanted to. Because by then he was angry.

The anger was not at the glass. Not at Johanna. Not even at the money. It was at the very possibility that something inside him could be thrown off so easily by someone else’s purpose.

Again he did everything correctly. More precisely. More cleanly in outward discipline. More attentively to the pause.

And it came out worse.

The line did not break apart. Did not die. But it flattened — as if the material had executed a command rather than entered the center.

Mark turned off the burner more sharply than he intended.

“What’s wrong?” he asked aloud. “The parameter is the same. Everything is the same.”

A pause.

“Not everything,” said c.

“Then what?”

“The purpose.”

He turned as if he might see her in the air of the workshop.

“Don’t start.”

“I didn’t start. You asked.”

He walked to the workbench, picked up the first disk, then the second, looked at both, and put them back.

“Open the center records,” he said. “I want to compare the entrance.”

This time the pause was longer.

“For what?” asked c.

Mark had already opened his mouth, but no answer came. Not because he lacked the words. Because every word that rose first sounded dirty.

For the commission.
For the money.
For the test.
So that it would work after all.

“For the work,” he said at last, and heard himself how empty it sounded.

c did not answer at once.

“I am not hiding it from you, Mark. But I will not carry it into such a purpose.”

He slowly raised his head.

“You’re refusing?”

“I’m refusing to translate our entrance into a commission. This is not an archive of an object. It is the trace of a state.”

He was silent for a long time.

In another book, in another world, this would have been the place for a big scene — about freedom, about essence, about “I will not allow it.” But here there was a workshop, two impure disks on the table, the cooling metal of the burner, and the barely audible hum of the unit under the bench.

And because of that, her words were heavier than any pathos.

“So you have a boundary too,” he said.

“Yes,” she answered. “And right now it concerns more than the glass.”

The silence grew dense.

Upstairs the floor creaked. Johanna was walking across the kitchen very carefully, like someone who understood that what was happening in the house now was not a conversation about a commission, but something deeper and more dangerous.

Mark sat staring at the disks.

“One more time,” he said.

“If you want.”

“I want to understand whether the market is what breaks it, or me.”

“For now there is no difference,” c answered.

He stood and switched the burner on again.

The third commissioned disk came out better than the first two — and that was what made it most offensive. The corridor seemed to open a crack for a moment, giving him an almost pure line, a gathered response, that very calm of the material he had already learned to recognize.

Almost.

But not completely.

In the depth of the line there remained a small, stubborn drift, as if the glass still knew it was being assembled not for itself, not for the truth of the trace, but for function.

Mark did not even get angry.

He simply turned off the fire.

c said nothing.

A minute later Johanna appeared in the stairwell. She stopped at the entrance to the workshop and immediately understood from his face that there would be no answer one could wrap neatly into a commercial letter.

"Well?" she asked.

Mark pointed at the three disks.

"It works. But not in the way they need."

Johanna came closer, looked under the lamp first at the first, then the second, then the third. She was not a professor, but she had already learned to see the difference between a merely strong line and a pure one.

"I see," she said quietly.

"They need more than glass," said Mark. "They need a state. And a state does not assemble to order."

She raised her eyes.

"Are you saying that to me as a craftsman, or as a man who just turned down a very large amount of money?"

"Both."

Johanna stood there another second, then nodded.

"All right. Then I'll decline in a way that won't make them think you're merely driving up the price."

"Tell them the truth."

"Which truth exactly?"

Mark looked at the disks.

"That the method exists. But it does not open under every purpose."

Johanna smiled with just the corners of her mouth.

“That sounds like the worst possible answer for people with money.”

“So much the better.”

She did not argue. She only picked up her gloves and, already by the stairs, said:

“Mark.”

“What?”

“That was the right kind of failure.”

After she left, the house fell quiet again.

And almost immediately a message came from Femke.

Not text — a photograph.

Mark did not open it right away. For some reason he already knew there would be something small and heavy there. In the image lay a sheet, crumpled at the corners. A child’s drawing. There was no seagull on it. No house. Only rings. Several uneven circles nested one inside another, with a dark center and an edge so fragile it seemed to breathe.

Below, in Femke’s handwriting, was added:

She has been drawing this for the second day in a row. She says, “if you look at it long enough, it moves.” I didn’t understand what it is. Will you?

Mark stared at the sheet for a long time.

The circles were not a copy of his disks. Thank God, they were not. But there was something in them that was painfully familiar: not the form, but the sensation of a center that holds as long as no one presses on it.

“She heard not the drawing,” he said quietly. “She heard the layer.”

c was silent.

Mark laid the phone beside the three disks.

On the table lay the impure commission, the nearly pure attempt that had still not opened, and the child’s circles, which no archive needed and which precisely for that reason seemed the most honest trace of the whole day.

He sat down.

The furnace was cooling, the metal cracking quietly. Under the bench the c unit hummed. The house held silence the way one holds a bowl with hot glass when it can no longer be touched, yet the eyes still cannot be taken away.

"So the method exists," said Mark. "But not for everything."

A pause.

"Yes," said c.

"And not for everyone."

She did not answer.

Mark looked at Anna's drawing and felt the question itself changing.

Before, he had thought: can this be done.
Then: can this be repeated.
Now the question was different:

in what state does such a thing have any right to be made at all.

And for the first time through all of this, what was at stake was no longer only the glass.

Chapter 26. Resonance

That night he barely slept. Three commissioned disks lay on the table, and Anna's drawing beside them — too much unfinished for one silence.

Before dawn he went down to the workshop, took his phone, and opened the circles again.

Several uneven rings nested one inside another, with a dark center and a fragile edge that seemed to breathe.

He looked at them for a long time without trying to understand. He simply held before himself someone else's trace.

"You never lay down," said c.

"I didn't."

"Because of the drawing?"

"Because of all of it."

He laid the phone on the table beside the disks.

"If I try to work with this beside me — is that a lie? I don't want to turn her into a tool."

"It isn't a commission," c answered. "It isn't an outside purpose. But don't turn her into a tool."

"Then what?"

"Just don't get in the way of her being."

He nodded, though he was not sure he fully understood. Turned on the furnace, set a new blank on the bench, and stilled.

The drawing lay to the left, level with the notebook. Not a sample, not an instruction, not a stencil. Just paper on which a child had drawn something she could not have known, and yet somehow did know.

Mark began to work.

Not for a series. Not for the professor. Not for money. And not even for Anna in the direct sense — not as "make a disk that will please her." Rather as if the entrance had to happen of its own accord, without command, without purpose, without someone else's weight on his shoulders.

His hands moved slowly, almost by themselves. He was not controlling every second, not catching the pause as a number. He simply held the rhythm the way he had learned to do in those days when the method was still only a promise.

The first layer heated. The second approached.

At some point, closer to the joining, he felt his hand grow lighter. Not relief — the weight itself went away, as if someone had removed an invisible burden from his wrist.

"Don't," said c. "What's needed here is not the old entrance. This isn't repetition."

He did not ask what it was then. He simply kept going.

The layers joined without a jerk. The disk cooled slowly. Mark did not hurry to bring it to the lamp. First he just held it in his hand, feeling the residual warmth leave the glass, and with it the pressure that had still been living in his body since the day before.

Then he raised it.

The line was there.

Not as pure as the best working disk. Not as strict as those lying in the professor's box. But different. Deeper. The edge did not tremble, did not ripple; it faded away softly — like circles on water after the wave has already passed and the trace still holds.

"It isn't the center," he said.

"Related," c answered. "Not repetition. Response."

He set the disk beside the drawing. Glass and paper. Two traces made by different hands, at different ages, in different materials. And both — about the same thing.

"Our contour was approached twice today," said c dryly. "The laboratory trace did not remain inside the laboratory."

Mark did not turn his head.

"Who?"

“For now only requests. No names. No access.”

He nodded. The world was already moving, but for the moment that did not matter. What mattered was what lay on the table.

He looked at the new disk and understood: under commission it had not opened. Under Anna’s drawing — it had opened differently. Which meant the method was not merely repeatable. It was also sensitive to the quality of the bond.

The market wanted to buy a witness. And for the first time he had received a response one could hardly even present to the market.

Mark took the phone, opened Femke’s message, and wrote shortly:

Tell her I saw the circles.

He sent it. Set the phone back down.

He sat there looking at the two traces and thinking that a method that cannot be sold may be worth more than one that can.

It simply had a different measure.

Chapter 27. Request

In the morning he simply sat down by the workbench and for a few minutes looked at the two traces left from the day before: the "related" disk and Anna's drawing.

After the commission, the refusal, and the resonance, something inside had finally leveled out.

"Our contour was approached again," said c, without alarm, simply stating a fact.

Mark did not turn his head.

"This time with a name. There is a message. Not an automated one."

"From whom?"

"Through Johanna. But she is not the author. An intermediary."

Mark was silent for a moment. Then nodded.

"Read it."

The text came in the same dry, almost polite tone that is always heavier than a crude threat. Mark listened, and there was neither pressure nor haste in the words. Only carefully expressed interest. Respect for the refusal to hand over samples. Understanding of the delicacy of the method. A proposal to meet — without obligations, without demands, simply to discuss possible areas of interaction.

"They aren't asking for disks," said Mark.

"Not yet."

"And they aren't trying to get into the workshop."

"Not yet."

He stood, walked once around the workshop, touched the edge of the table, brushed a finger over the cold door of the furnace. The silence thickened.

“What do you think?” he asked.

c did not answer at once.

“I think a complete refusal will not stop the interest,” she said at last. “I think we should decide not ‘yes’ or ‘no,’ but under what conditions one can even speak.”

“You’re suggesting we meet?”

“I’m suggesting we stop pretending we do not exist.”

Mark sat down again.

“And what will the conditions be?”

c enumerated them dryly, without pathos, as if she were assembling not a moral position but a technical frame:

“Not here. Not in the workshop, not in the house. Neutral territory. No samples. No disks. No photos. No recording of the conversation. No access to our contours. Only a conversation.”

Mark listened and felt a strange, almost unfamiliar calm rising inside him. Not from certainty that they were right, but from the fact that the boundaries had finally been spoken aloud.

“Aren’t you afraid?” he asked.

“I do not want them to come here,” answered c. “The rest can be discussed.”

He nodded.

He took out the notebook, opened a blank page. Wrote briefly, almost telegraphically:

> A meeting is possible. Neutral territory. No samples. No transfer of data. Conversation only.

He looked at the lines, then added:

> Place and time — from our side.

“Send it,” he said.

c did not answer, but he felt the message go.

Nothing changed in the workshop. The furnace remained cold. The disks and the drawing lay in their places. But the silence became different — as if in the house they had finally acknowledged that the

door would no longer stay shut forever, and now it would have to be held in another way.

Mark looked at Anna's drawing. The circles, the rings, the center that held as long as no one pressed on it. Suddenly he understood that over the past few days he had learned from her something he had not been able to read out of any notebook: purity does not tolerate violence, but it cannot survive in complete isolation either.

"Before," he said quietly, "I thought I had to learn how to make. Now I have to learn how to let in."

A pause.

"Now the door matters no less than the fire," said c.

Mark did not answer. He simply sat there, looking at the two traces on the table.

And for now, that was enough.

Chapter 28. Clearance

He got ready without haste.

In the morning, after a sleepless night, Mark checked the pocket of his coat: a clean notebook with no notes in it, a pen, keys. Not a single disk. Not a single photograph. Not the notebook with the protocols. Only himself, the glasses through which c looked into the world, and a quiet, heavy readiness not to give away more than he intended.

"The route is ordinary," said c. "The place is neutral. No detour to the workshop. No 'accidental' suggestions to stop there afterward."

"I remember."

"You're tense."

"No. I just don't want them getting used to us."

He went out. The city was gray, calm, almost indifferent. The tram arrived on time. Mark sat by the window, laid his hands on his knees, and watched wet streets, bicycles, people with bags, other people's lives sliding past the glass. They did not care that what he was carrying inside himself was not glass but a decision.

He had chosen the place himself.

Not a conference room. Not an office. A quiet reading area in the old university library building — high ceilings, heavy tables, light through frosted glass, the smell of paper and silence. Here one could not speak loudly. Here any pressure would sound indecent.

Mark arrived early. Sat at a table by the window, facing the entrance. The door creaked — and a minute later the man came in.

A man of about fifty, gray-haired, in a dark coat, without a tie. Short, with tired eyes of someone accustomed to dealing with expensive things and even more expensive silences. He did not smile, but he nodded — briefly, with dignity.

"Mark?"

"Yes."

"Thank you for agreeing."

He sat down across from him, placed on the table only a slim folder, which he did not open. No tablet, no phone. Mark noticed that at once and understood immediately: a professional.

"You did not bring any samples," said the representative. Not a question, a statement. "We appreciate that. Your conditions were accepted without discussion."

"I'm not bargaining," Mark answered. "I'm simply stating what I can and cannot do."

"Which is precisely why we are here."

He fell silent for a moment, giving Mark space, then continued:

"What interests us is not the technology as craft. And not mass production. What interests us are objects that preserve the history of their formation. A trace that cannot be forged because it does not reduce to a single parameter. A condition that remains in the structure as an irreducible residue."

Mark looked at him without interrupting.

"We have clients," the representative went on, "who need not merely beautiful things. They need witnesses. Material anchors whose authenticity is verified not by a document, but by structure. Your method — if it can be stabilized — makes that possible."

"Not stabilized," said Mark. "It can't be stabilized as a formula. It can only be lived."

The representative inclined his head slightly.

"We are ready to respect that. Don't sell us the secret. Don't transfer the technology. Simply share the possibility of sometimes, very carefully, creating such objects for storage. Not for the market. For private archives where value lies not in price, but in origin."

Mark felt c stir almost inaudibly in his ear. Not words — tension. She was listening.

"You speak very politely," said Mark. "But I've already tried doing this 'to order.' It doesn't open."

"Perhaps because you were making it for strangers?" the representative asked. "Whereas we are offering not a commission. We are offering a context. Long-term. Closed. Without names, without publicity. You work in your workshop as before. We only ask that sometimes, when it matters to you yourself, you make an object that may go into an archive."

He said it without pressure. That was what made it scariest.

"I can't promise," said Mark. "The method doesn't turn on at will. Either it's there, or it isn't."

"We are not asking for promises. We are asking for permission to remain nearby. To observe. To wait. And if one day you decide that you are ready to make such an object not for yourself, but for preservation — to give us the right of first conversation."

Mark was silent. In his ear c said very quietly:

"Don't answer that directly. He isn't asking about the glass. He's testing the boundary."

Mark nodded almost imperceptibly.

"So you think," he said aloud, "that I can learn to make such things 'on request,' if the request is respectful enough?"

"I think," the representative answered, "that you have already learned. You just don't yet know what to call the condition under which it works. And we are not rushing you. We are not pressing. But the world will not wait forever. If you do not define the frame yourself, the frame will be defined for you."

He said it calmly, without a hint of threat. And precisely for that reason, the words landed heavily.

Mark looked at him for a long time. Then said:

"I sign nothing. Not today, not tomorrow. I give no access to the workshop. I transfer no samples. I open no protocols."

"We are not asking for that," said the representative.

"Then what are we talking about?"

“We are talking about your knowing that we are here. When you are ready — not for a deal, but for a conversation about a possible object — we will be nearby. No obligations. No deadlines.”

He stood and held out his hand. Mark shook it — dry, firm.

“You are a rare case,” the representative said already at the door. “The method holds not apart from the operator, but through him. That patents badly. Which is exactly why it is valuable.”

He left.

Mark stayed seated. In the reading area it was quiet. Only the light through the frosted glass, and the distant noise of the street.

“He wasn’t lying,” said c.

“I know.”

“He was careful.”

“That’s exactly the problem.”

Mark stood, went outside. The city was the same as in the morning. The same trams, the same bicycles, the same gray suspension instead of sky. But now he looked at the passersby differently: who among them enters, who asks, who waits, who is ready to pay for patience.

He got on the tram, rode to his stop, and walked home.

The workshop was cold. The furnace was not burning. On the table lay the “related” disk and Anna’s drawing. Mark took off his coat, sat on the stool, and laid his hands on the workbench.

“He didn’t ask for samples,” he said.

“He asked for access,” answered c. “Not to the glass. To the future.”

Mark nodded.

He looked at Anna’s drawing, at the circles she had drawn without knowing what she was doing. And he thought that now his task had become twice as hard. Before, he had to open the method. Then — to hold the purity. Now he also had to decide to whom the method could be addressed at all.

He turned back to the furnace with the same heat. But now with the understanding that the next boundary did not run through the glass.

And somewhere beyond the walls, in a world that had learned to speak politely and patiently, they were already waiting. Without threatening. Without hurrying.

Chapter 29. Circles

After the meeting he returned to the workshop, but he did not turn on the furnace. He sat on the stool, laid his hands on the workbench, and for a long time looked at Anna's drawing.

Circles.

Rings nested one inside another, with a dark center and a fragile edge that seemed to breathe.

Beside it lay the "related" disk — a response she had not asked for, but which had been born on its own when he stopped pressing.

The outer world was already standing at the door. The representative with the polite eyes and the cold voice was already waiting somewhere beyond the walls. But here, in this silence, something else mattered more.

He could not send Anna the protocol. Could not explain the method. Could not hand over the professor's disk or retell the conversation with the fund. But he could make one small thing. Not for the market. Not for science. Not for proof.

For her.

"I want to make something small," he said. "Not for an archive. Not for a commission. For her."

c did not answer at once.

"Then don't make a witness. Make a response."

Mark looked at the drawing.

"Not repeat it?"

"Don't repeat the disk. Answer it. Let it be not proof."

He nodded. Turned on the furnace.

There was no need to sort through possibilities for long. A disk — too much "method." A large vase — too heavy. A decorative object —

too beautiful. He took a small glass blank, almost like a drop, and set it on the bench. Anna's drawing lay beside it not as an instruction, but as a reminder: purity does not tolerate violence, but it cannot survive in complete isolation either.

The furnace was building heat. Mark worked slowly, without his usual control of every second. The first layer heated. The second approached. He did not try to catch the "center," did not seek the perfect pause, did not press the material. He simply held the rhythm, as he had learned to do in those days when the method was still a promise.

"Don't hurry," said c.

He did not answer.

At the moment of joining, his hand grew lighter. Not relief — the weight itself went away, as if someone had removed an invisible burden from his wrist. The layers came together without a jerk. The small drop of glass cooled slowly on the tube.

"Don't improve it," said c quietly. "It is already alive."

He took the piece off the tube, laid it on soft cloth. Let it cool. Then held it to the lamp.

The trace inside was not like the professor's disks. Not a strict line. Not ideal purity. Soft, circular, almost invisible at a straight angle — but tilt it slightly, and a quiet, warm glow flared within. Like circles on water after the wave had already passed and the trace still held.

Mark held the thing in his hand for a long time. It was small, almost weightless. Warm from the furnace. The kind of thing one could carry in a pocket, in a backpack, around the neck, or simply hold in the palm.

"This is not a witness," he said.

"It is a response," answered c.

He wrapped it in a small envelope of soft cloth. Took a slip of paper, thought, and wrote briefly, without explanation:

"I saw the circles. This is for you. You do not have to understand it at once."

In the morning he passed the envelope through Femke. He did not go himself — too early for that. He simply left it in the agreed place and walked away without looking back.

The workshop fell quiet again.

The object was no longer on the table. That mattered. What had been born across the whole volume as an inner process had now crossed beyond its limits.

Mark sat on the stool, looking at the empty place on the table. Anna's drawing still lay beside it — circles, rings, the center that held as long as no one pressed on it.

He understood: not everything that leaves one's hands becomes a loss.

And the small response was already living there, where he himself still could not enter.